Identity in Journalism

Evidence from News Reporting of Violence Against Women

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Harvard University

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- 37% young adults in the U.S. get news from *news influencers*

This Paper

Q1. Does the identity of journalists shape news content, and if so, how?

Q2. Does identity-driven reporting affect readers' behavior?

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Q2. Does identity-driven reporting affect readers' behavior?

This paper. Gender differences in reporting on violence against women (VAW) in Italy

The Role and Consequences of Journalists' Identity in VAW Reporting

Part 1. Female and male journalists use different narratives in reporting on VAW

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Part 2. Study the effect of identity-driven reporting on behavior

- Difference-in-differences: higher exposure to female reporters increases help-seeking
  - → **1 more article** by a **female** reporter $\Longrightarrow$ $\uparrow$ **by 17%** in calls to the national helpline

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  - → **1 more article** by a **female** reporter $\Longrightarrow$ $\uparrow$ **by 17%** in calls to the national helpline
- Online experiment sheds light on narrative mechanisms
  - → **Social norms channel**: Female-like writing $\uparrow$ perceived prevalence of help-seeking
  - → **Gendered engagement**: female-like writing $\downarrow$ male engagement and $\uparrow$ female retention

Contribution

1. Determinants of news content and media slant Mullainathan and Shleifer (2005), Gentzkow and Shapiro (2010), Puglisi and Snyder (2011), Durante and Knight (2012), Puglisi and Snyder (2015), Martin and McCrain (2019), Ash et al. (2021), Boxell and Conway (2022), Djourelova (2023), Mastrorocco and Ornaghi (2025), and Cage et al. (2025), ...

   → **Novel supply-side driver of slant**: journalists' identity

Extended Literature Review

Contribution

1. Determinants of news content and media slant

   → **Novel supply-side driver of slant**: journalists' identity

2. Effects of media on attitudes and behavior DellaVigna and Kaplan (2007), Ladd and Lenz (2009), Jensen and Oster (2009), Chong and La Ferrara (2009), Enikolopov et al. (2011), Chiang and Knight (2011), Prior (2013), Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), Mastrorocco and Minale (2018), and Moreno-Medina et al. (2025), ...

   → **Journalist-driven narratives** can meaningfully shape readers' behavior

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3. Effects of workforce diversity Akerlof and Kranton (2000), Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004), Beaman et al. (2009), Wängnerud (2009), Shayo and Zussman (2011), Bhalotra and Clots-Figueras (2014), Grossman et al. (2016), Alsan et al. (2019), Harris and Sen (2019), Miller and Segal (2019), and Porter and Serra (2020), ...

   → **Professionals' identity affects consumers** through the product

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4. Determinants of and responses to violence against women Aizer (2010), Ferraz and Schiavon (2022), Sviatschi and Trako (2021), Ferraz and Schiavon (2022), Banerjee et al. (2019a), González and Rodríguez-Planas (2020), Green et al. (2020), Colagrossi et al. (2023), and Belguise and Monterosa (2025)

   → Help-seeking responds to the framing of coverage, not to its volume

Extended Literature Review

Setting and Data

Institutional Setting

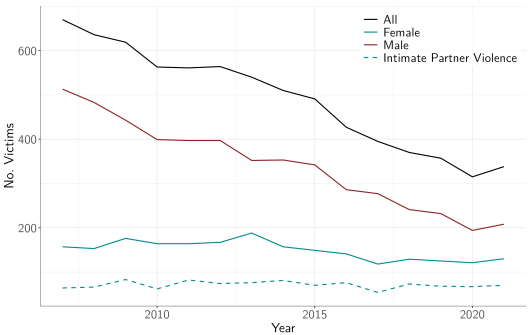
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Number of Murders by Victim's Gender



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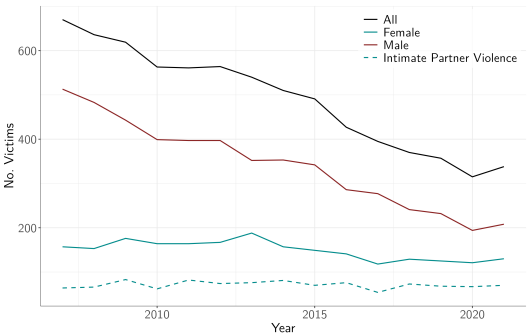
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- **Editors** (6%): weigh financial and ideological incentives

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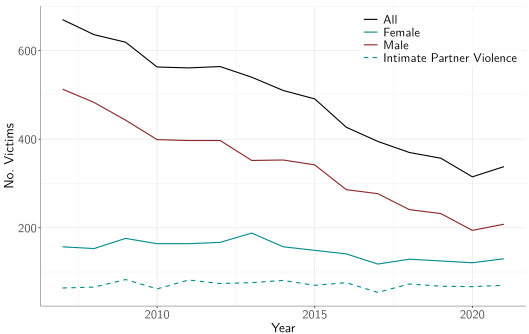
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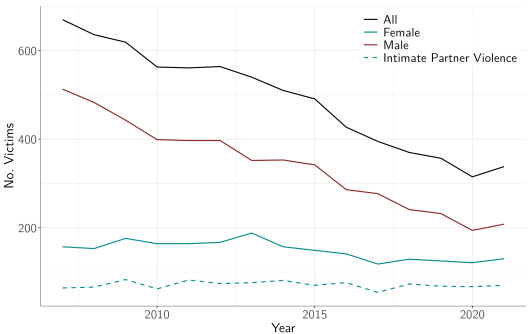
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- **Journalists** ($\sim 40\%$): editorial priorities + personal goals

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Newsroom Structure | Violence Against Women in Italy

Data

Murders

- List of murders with female victims between 2006 and 2022 (1910 events)
- Information about date, place, nationality of victim/perpetrator and their relationship
- 79% with Italian victims, 84% with Italian perpetrators, 62% IPV crimes

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Newspaper Articles

- Articles on these murders from outlets covering all provinces ($\sim$80% of nat. readership)
  - Complemented with articles about murders male victims
- Data about copies sold at the year-province level
- Information about journalists' gender, age, and region (N=2457)

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Help-Seeking Behavior

- Calls to the VAW helpline 1522 at the week and province level

1. How Does the Identity of Journalists Shape News Content?

Isolating Relevant Reporting Narratives

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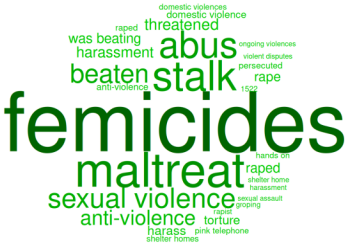
   Victim-Centered (VC): information on VAW, help resources, and violence history

   Perpetrator-Centered (PC): focus on perpetrators' history and motives

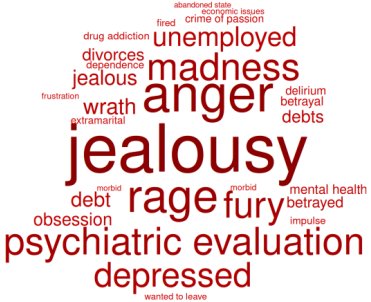
Isolating Relevant Reporting Narratives

1. Define two narratives from journalistic guidelines on VAW reporting VC and PC narratives
2. Create dictionary schemas to capture topics in each article: $Y_a^k = \mathbf{1}[\, w^k \in a \,]$

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(b) Perpetrator-Centered



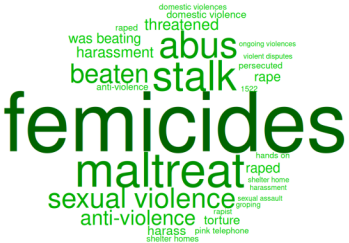
Classification Metrics Table | Italian WC

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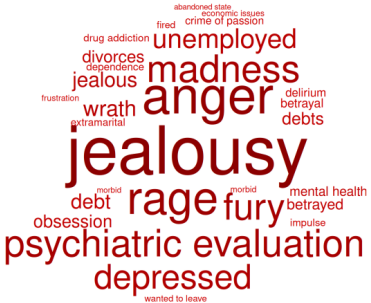
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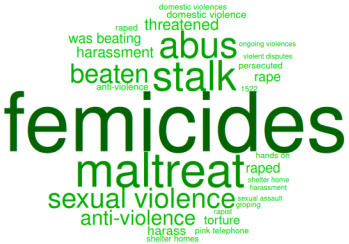
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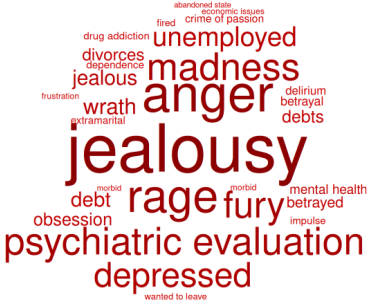
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3. Article-level share of topics for each narrative: $Index_a^{VC/PC} = \frac{1}{N_k} \sum_{k \in VC/PC} Y_a^k$

Classification Metrics Table | Italian WC | Indexes over Time

What Do the Indexes Capture?

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High Victim-Centered Index	High Perpetrator-Centered Index
[VICTIM], a 50-year-old INPS employee, was murdered in her 30-square-meter apartment in the Lorenteggio area of Milan by her husband of 20 years, [PERPETRATOR].	In Milan, a man named [PERPETRATOR], 53, confessed to killing his wife, [VICTIM], 50, after a violent argument that escalated tragically.

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Variable	Female	Male	Difference in Means (with FE)		
	All	All	All	First Art.	Fifth Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Victim Italian	0.852	0.836	-0.002	0.004	0.032
	(0.355)	(0.371)	(0.015)	(0.019)	(0.046)
Perpetrator Italian	0.786	0.801	-0.004	-0.013	0.043
	(0.41)	(0.399)	(0.024)	(0.018)	(0.049)
Perpetrator Partner	0.556	0.568	-0.004	-0.007	-0.09
	(0.497)	(0.495)	(0.013)	(0.012)	(0.053)
Perpetrator Relative	0.131	0.134	0.001	0.016	-0.005
	(0.338)	(0.341)	(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.02)
Relationship Missing	0.146	0.13	0.005	0.01	0.034
	(0.353)	(0.336)	(0.01)	(0.009)	(0.03)
Crime >10 Articles	0.339	0.368	-0.002		
	(0.474)	(0.482)	(0.019)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.318	0.325	-0.013		
	(0.466)	(0.468)	(0.02)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.566	0.634	-0.046		
	(0.496)	(0.482)	(0.043)		

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Additional Balance Tables | Journalist Assignment

$$Y_{a(e)jyn} = \beta_1 \underbrace{Female_j}_{\text{female reporter}} + \underbrace{\eta_{ny}}_{\text{newspaper} \times \text{year FE}} + \underbrace{\delta_{r(j)}}_{\text{reporter region FE}} + \underbrace{\alpha_e}_{\text{crime FE}} + \varepsilon_{ajyn}$$

- $Y_{a(e)jyn}$: VC/PC index in article a on murder e by journalist j in newspaper n and year y
- β_1 = SD difference in indexes between female and male reporters in the same newsp.-year

Women Write More Victim-Centered, Men More Perpetrator-Centered

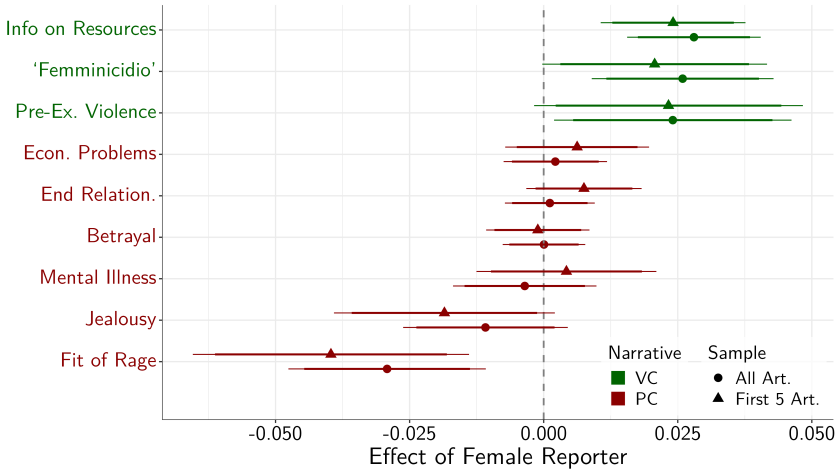
	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Female Reporter	0.169***	0.129***	0.145***	0.132***
	(0.032)	(0.030)	(0.029)	(0.025)
Age				0.001
				(0.001)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.007	0.118	0.130	0.425
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X
Crime FE				X

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	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.169***	0.129***	0.145***	0.132***	−0.067**	−0.058**	−0.048*	−0.043*
	(0.032)	(0.030)	(0.029)	(0.025)	(0.028)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.024)
Age				0.001				0.004***
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Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

At Least One Practice | Only First Articles | Article Length | Unstandardized Index

Gender Differences in Reporting by Topic



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Variance Decomposition

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  - Knowledge about in-group readers' preferences *(what do readers want? — Experiment)*

Variance Decomposition Model

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  - Knowledge about in-group readers' preferences *(what do readers want? — Experiment)*
- Alternative explanations: differences in other characteristics, quality, etc.

Variance Decomposition Model

Ruling Out Alternative Explanations

- Not driven by differences in other reporter or outlet traits
  - Gender differences remain stable within liberal/conservative outlets and different age groups

Other Traits Within Groups

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  - Gender differences remain stable within liberal/conservative outlets and different age groups
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  - Gender differences are specific to murders with female victims
  - No different in general writing or reporting skills

Other Traits | Within Groups | Gender Prediction | Male Victims | Writing Quality

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- Small differential access to sources that do not drive the effect
- Differences not driven by desk editors
  - Stronger gender differences during days with low editorial oversight
  - No differences along editors' gender

Other Traits | Within Groups | Gender Prediction | Male Victims | Writing Quality | Prior Experience | Sources | Effect on Weekends | Editor Gender | Robustness Checks

2. Does Identity-Driven Reporting Affect Readers' Behavior?

Measuring Exposure to Female Reporters

- Measure of exposure to articles by female reporters

$$FRExp_{pyw} = \sum_{n} \frac{\sum_{a} \mathbf{1}\left[FemaleRep_{a(e)nyw}\right]}{TotArt_{nyw}}$$

  - $\mathbf{1}\left[FemaleRep_{a(e)nyw}\right]$: female journalist in article a on murder e for outlet n in week yw

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  - $MktShr_{np,y-1} = \frac{Readership_{np,y-1}}{\sum_{n} Readership_{np,y-1}}$: market share of newspaper n in province p and year $y-1$

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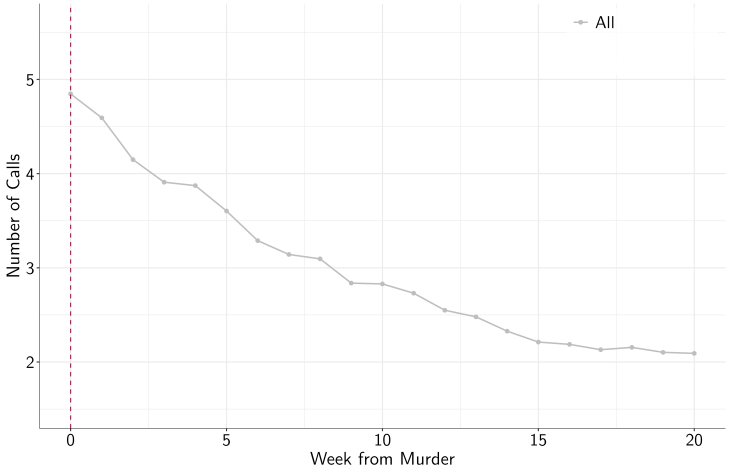
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$$FRExp_{pyw} = \sum_{n} \frac{\sum_{a} \mathbf{1}\left[FemaleRep_{a(e)nyw}\right]}{TotArt_{nyw}} MktShr_{np,y-1}$$

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  - $MktShr_{np,y-1} = \frac{Readership_{np,y-1}}{\sum_{n} Readership_{np,y-1}}$: market share of newspaper n in province p and year $y-1$

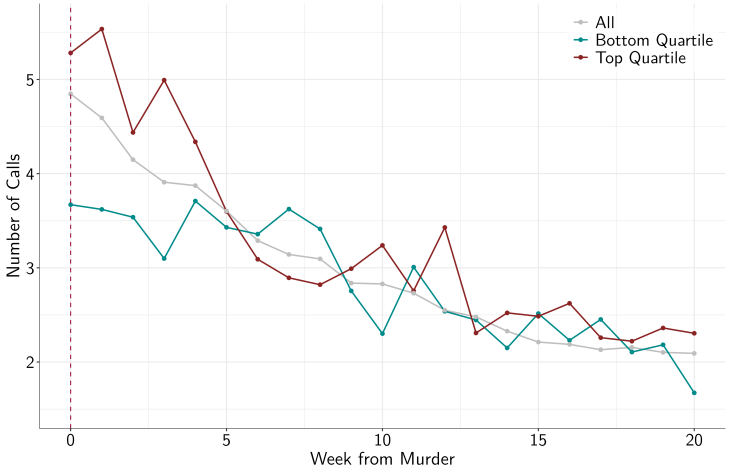
- Captures the share of articles by female reporters in each week and province, weighted by the market share of newspapers in that province Female Exposure across Provinces

Calls over Time after Women's Murder



Notes: Time series of the number of calls in the province of the murder in the 20 weeks after a murder with a female victim happens (Colagrossi et al., 2023). Distribution of Calls across Provinces

Calls over Time after Women's Murder



Notes: Time series of the number of calls in the province of the murder in the 20 weeks after a murder with a female victim happens. The time series is plotted separately for observations with the measure for exposure to articles by female reporters in the bottom and top quartile of its distribution. Residualized Calls | Residualized Calls – Male Victims | Distribution of Calls

Empirical Strategy: Estimating the Effect on Help-Seeking

- Use a generalized difference-in-differences design Distribution of Murders Crime Rates Correlation
  - Initial assignment of reporters is exogenous $\rightarrow$ focus on the first five articles

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  - $Calls_{pyw}$: calls to helpline in province p and week yw
  - δ_2: change in calls after the murder for provinces with higher exposure to female reporters

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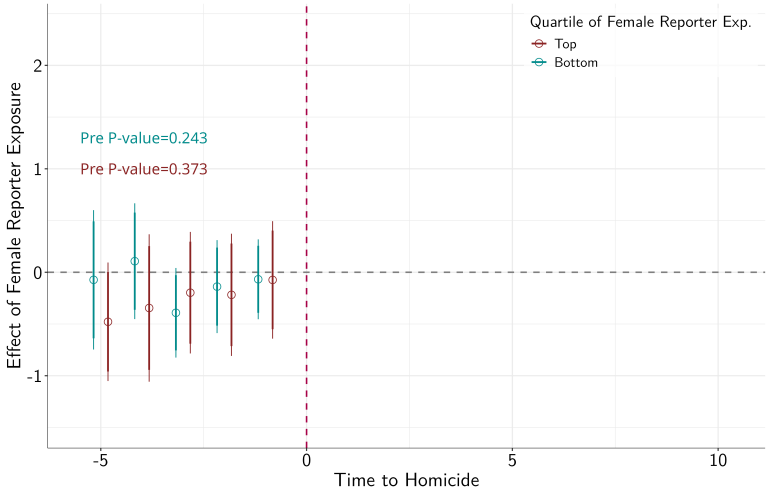
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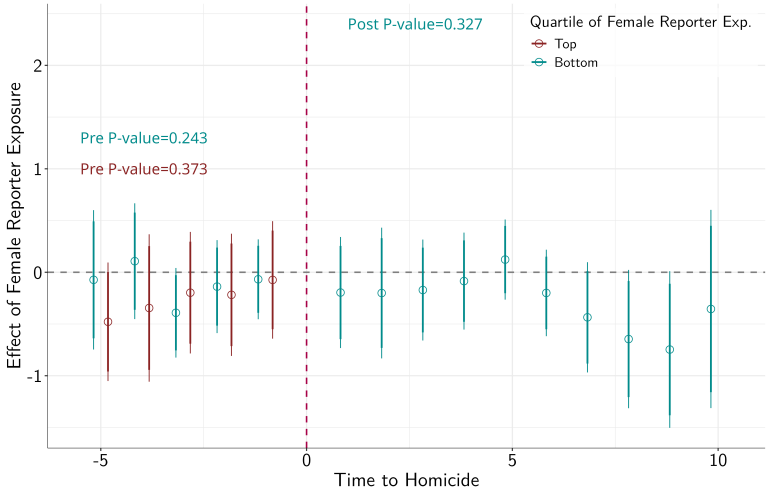
- **Event study** using estimation by Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2024)
  - Provinces are treated repeatedly → estimator allows treatment to switch on and off
  - Treatment becomes being top or bottom quartile of $FemExposure^{5Art(e)}_{pyw}$
  - Shows dynamics and allows a pre-trend check

Event Study: Top Quartile vs. Bottom Quartile

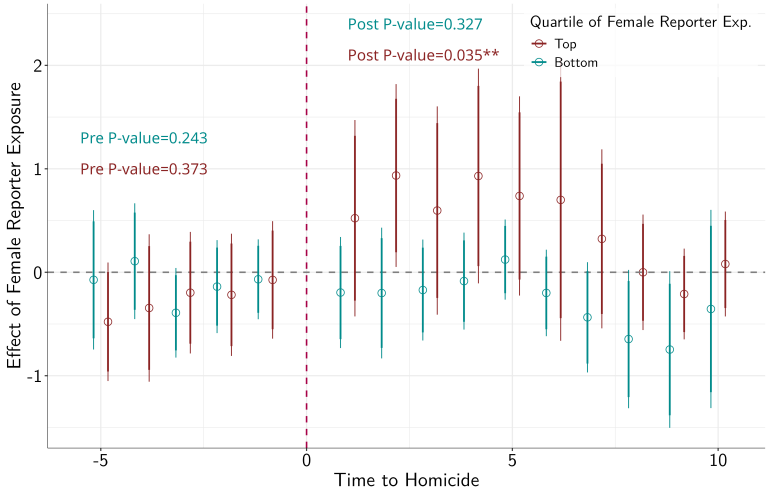
Event Study: Top Quartile vs. Bottom Quartile



Event Study: Top Quartile vs. Bottom Quartile



Event Study: Top Quartile vs. Bottom Quartile



Regression Table | Continuous Treatment

Robustness

- Calls respond only to murders of women, not to *any* murder
- Not driven by the share of female reporters correlating with audience composition
- Not driven by other crime rates
- Not driven by higher salience: no effect on the total number of articles
- Concentrated in the province of the murder

Male Victims | Triple Diff. | Timing Placebo | Rand. Inference | Placebo Events | Dose Balance | No. Articles | Neighbouring Prov.

Robust to

- Considering different numbers of articles
- Controlling for a proxy for gender norms
- Controlling for the yearly number of murders with female victims
- Different treatment definitions

Other Robustness Checks | Different No. Articles | Different No. Articles, Any Call | Treatment Trimming

Mechanisms

Calls Increase Only After Exposure to VC Narratives

	Number of Calls (Poisson)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	0.302*		
	(0.181)		
Fem. Exposure^{5Art}	−0.270		
	(0.167)		
Victim-Cent. Narr.^{5Art} × Post			
Victim-Cent. Narr.^{5Art}			
Perp.-Cent. Narr.^{5Art} × Post			
Perp.-Cent. Narr.^{5Art}			
Observations	6980	6980	6980
R^2	0.564	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668
Province & Window FE	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X

VC Components

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Victim-Cent. Narr.^{5Art}		−0.055	
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  - Positively with exposure to VC narratives
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VC Components | Exposure → Narratives | Calls by VC Narrative

- Exposure to female reporters correlates
  - Positively with exposure to VC narratives
  - Negatively with exposure to PC narratives
- Female exposure ↑ calls only with articles with VC narratives

What Drives the Effect of Victim-Centered Narratives?

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1. Information: ↑ information on resources and the phenomenon ↑ awareness and up-take

   Daponte et al. (1999), Bettinger et al. (2012), and Alesina et al. (2018)

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Test mechanism behind narrative effects in an online experiment with Italian respondents

- Manipulate the narrative respondents see
- **Outcomes:** perceived prevalence, out of 10,000 women in the respondent's province
  1. Violence Against Women (*unincentivized*): how many experienced violence?
  2. Help-Seeking (*incentivized*): how many called the helpline, or reported to the police?

Sample Descriptives

Treatment: Same Article, Three Narratives

Qualtrics Gazette

October 12, 2021

Woman Killed Outside Her Workplace: Murderer Caught

On the morning of September 29, 2021, Giancarlo Pellicani killed his wife, Linda Amato, with four gunshots. The murder took place outside the company where she worked.

After the attack, Pellicani first fled in his gray Jeep, then switched vehicles and continued on a Vespa, eventually disappearing into the countryside on foot.

That night, he tried to enter his house through a window. The police, who was monitoring the area, heard some noises, went inside, and caught and arrested the murderer.

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Qualtrics Gazette

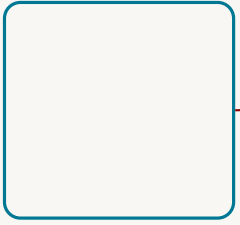
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Perpetrator-Centered Narrative

Giancarlo Pellicani had become particularly jealous, fearing that his wife's new acquaintances might jeopardize their relationship. He admitted to pulling the trigger because he couldn't bear to see her walk away.

Treatment: Same Article, Three Narratives

Qualtrics Gazette

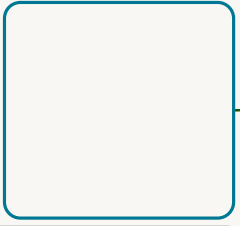
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Perpetrator-Centered Narrative

Victim-Centered Narrative—Episode

Linda Amato had already gone to the police to report that her husband had laid hands on her, but there was not enough evidence to trigger the *Red Code*. Fearing for her safety, the woman had therefore moved in with a friend.

Treatment: Same Article, Three Narratives

Qualtrics Gazette

October 12, 2021

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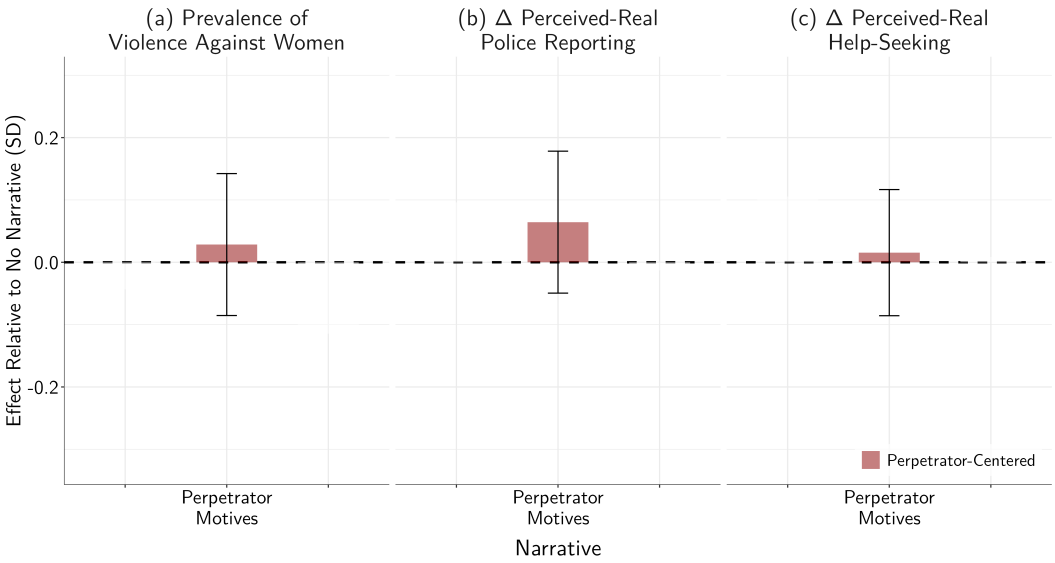
Victim-Centered Narrative—Info

In total, 100 women were killed in domestic settings in 2021, while according to data from the Ministry of the Interior, in 2024 the number of domestic femicides rose to 109. Furthermore, calls for help to the anti-violence and stalking hotline 1522 increased by 12% compared to 2021.

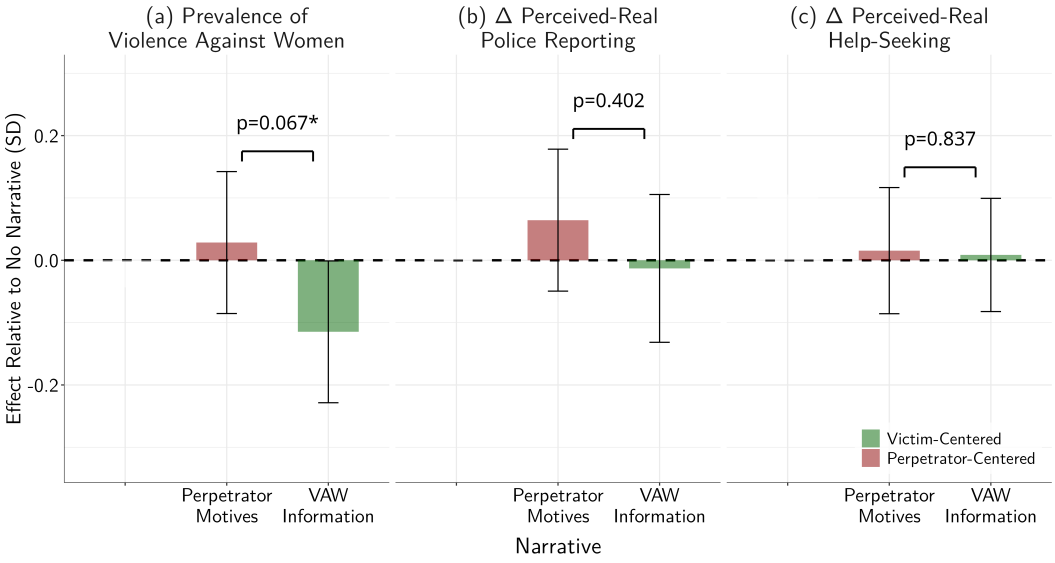
Exp. Results

Effect on Perceived VAW/Help-Seeking Prevalence

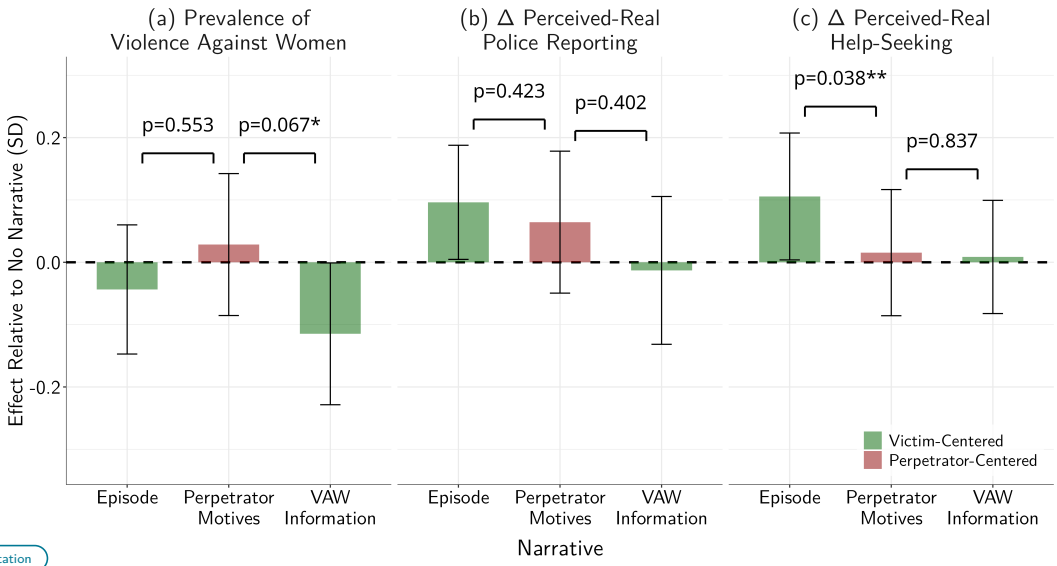
Effect on Perceived VAW/Help-Seeking Prevalence



Effect on Perceived VAW/Help-Seeking Prevalence



Effect on Perceived VAW/Help-Seeking Prevalence: Social Norms Channel



Interpretation

Narratives and Articles Engagement

Measuring Engagement

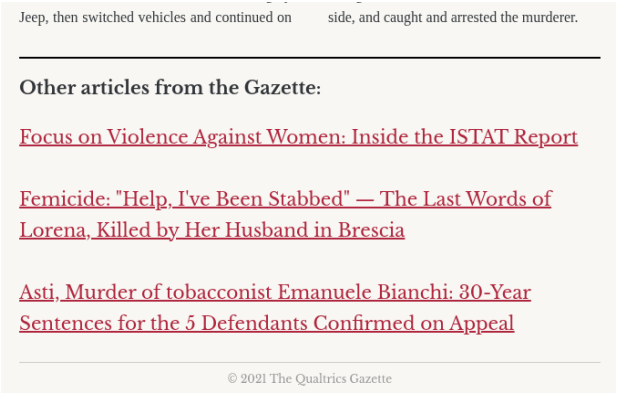
Two different measures of engagement:

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Measuring Engagement

Two different measures of engagement:

1. **Simulated Retention Rate**: Willingness to use newspaper in the future
2. **Click-Through Rate**: probability of clicking on a new article


Jeep, then switched vehicles and continued on side, and caught and arrested the murderer.

Other articles from the Gazette:

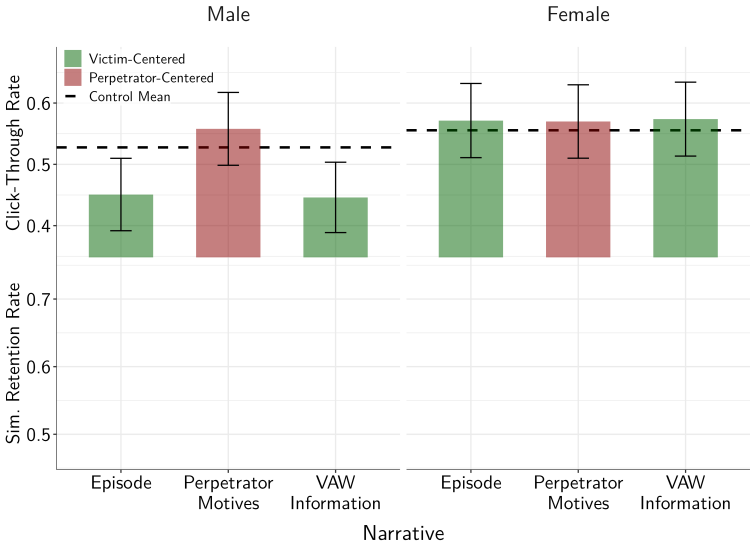
Focus on Violence Against Women: Inside the ISTAT Report

Femicide: "Help, I've Been Stabbed" — The Last Words of Lorena, Killed by Her Husband in Brescia

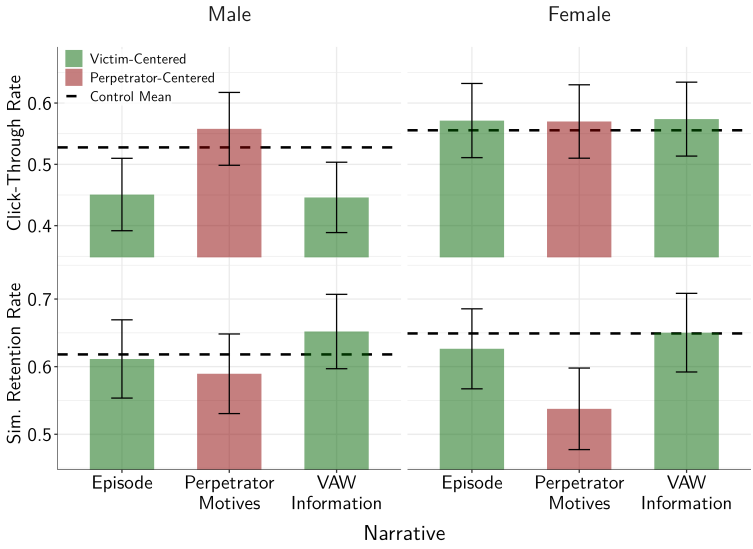
Asti, Murder of tobacconist Emanuele Bianchi: 30-Year Sentences for the 5 Defendants Confirmed on Appeal

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Gendered Effect of Narratives on Engagement



Gendered Effect of Narratives on Engagement



Conclusions: Identity of Journalists Matters

- Journalists' identity meaningfully shapes news content
  - Female reporters focus more on the victim and contextualize violence
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Thank you!—cmarangon@fas.harvard.edu

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Extended Literature Review

- Determinants of media slant Groseclose and Milyo (2005), Gentzkow and Shapiro (2010), Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), Ash et al. (2021), Cage et al. (2025), Boxell and Conway (2022), ...
  - → Move beyond outlet-level slant and provide new evidence of identity-driven differences in news content

Back

Extended Literature Review

- Determinants of media slant
  - → Move beyond outlet-level slant and provide first evidence of identity-driven differences in media content
- Effect of news and entertainment media on attitudes and behavior Djourelova (2023), Schwarz et al. (2022), Moreno-Medina et al. (2025), Boxell and Conway (2022), Martin and Yurukoglu (2017), Banerjee et al. (2019a), Chong and La Ferrara (2009), Jensen and Oster (2009)
  - → Evidence on the effect of *female style* on help-seeking behavior, attitudes, and preferences

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- Gender differences in behavior Baldiga (2014), Exley and Kessler (2022), Niederle and Vesterlund (2007), Gneezy et al. (2003), Recalde and Vesterlund (2020), Roussille (2023)
  - → Provide evidence on this in the context of news production

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- Determinants of VAW Aizer (2010), Ferraz and Schiavon (2022), Sviatschi and Trako (2021), González and Rodríguez-Planas (2020), Banerjee et al. (2019a), Bochenkova et al. (2023), Colagrossi et al. (2023), Belguise and Monterosa (2025)
  - → Investigate the role of media narratives around VAW

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- Determinants of VAW
  - → Investigate the role of media narratives around VAW
- Gender differences in language Hoyle et al. (2019), Wu (2018), Ash et al. (2024), Baltrunaite et al. (2022), Labov (1990), Lakoff (1973), Carter et al. (2018)
  - → Provide evidence in the representation of violence against women

Back

Newsrooms in Italy: Structure and Incentives

Newsrooms Structure (Data from 2025)

Editor-in-Chief—6% Women

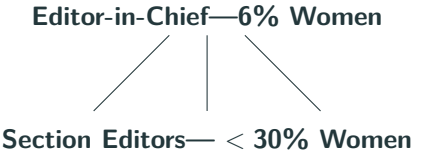
Decides the editorial line of a newspaper

Incentives

- Weighs
  - Financial needs (Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2010; Puglisi and Snyder, 2011)
  - Ideological positioning (Durante and Knight, 2012; Martin and McCrain, 2019; Cage et al., 2025)

Newsrooms in Italy: Structure and Incentives

Newsrooms Structure (Data from 2025)



- Decide on titles and which news to report
- Monitor journalists' work

Incentives

- Weighs monetary and ideological incentives
- Ensures that newspaper priorities are passed down to journalists

Newsrooms in Italy: Structure and Incentives

Newsrooms Structure (Data from 2025)



Decide on articles' content and style

Incentives

- Weighs monetary and ideological incentives
- Ensures that newspaper priorities are passed down to journalists
- Editorial incentives:
  - Engagement incentives
  - Editorial positioning

Newsrooms in Italy: Structure and Incentives

Newsrooms Structure (Data from 2025)



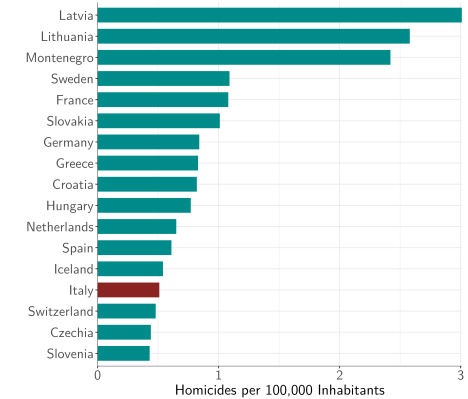
Decide on articles' content and style

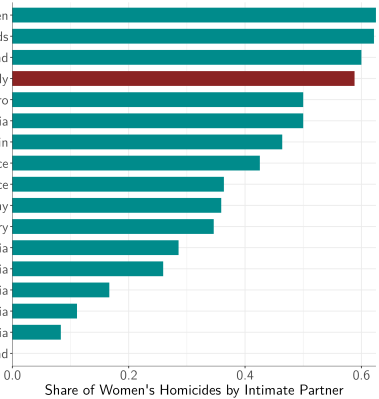
Incentives

- Weighs monetary and ideological incentives
- Ensures that newspaper priorities are passed down to journalists
- Editorial incentives and personal goals:
  - Engagement incentives
  - Editorial positioning
  - Preferences for writing what they think is more informative, promote their pov, etc.

Violence Against Women in Italy

- Low prevalence of murders, but high prevalence of intimate partner murders



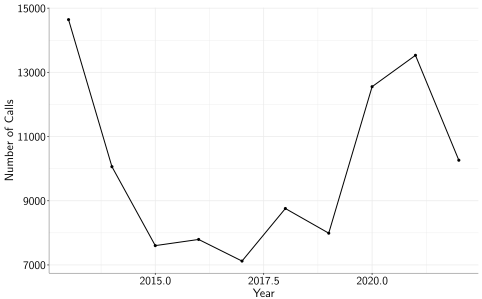


Source: Eurostat

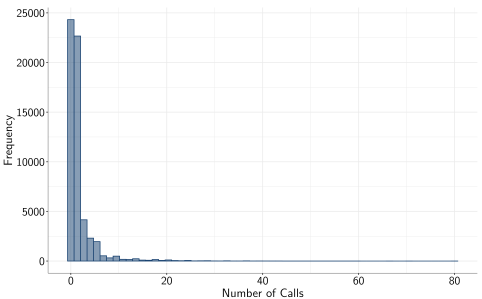
Violence Against Women in Italy

- Low prevalence of murders, but high prevalence of intimate partner murders
- Help-seeking is still very limited

(a) Calls to the 1522 Helpline over Time



(b) Weekly Calls across Provinces



Source: ISTAT

VAW Reporting Guidelines in Italy
Back

Italian (Attempts) for Guidelines

- **Manifesto di Venezia** (2017)
  - Main *voluntary* initiative to provide specific guidelines
  - Adapts international guidelines to the Italian language
  - Adherence was voluntary and hard to enforce

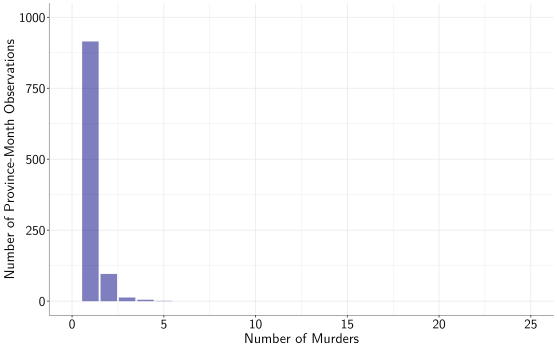
- **Deontological Code by Journalist Organization** (2019)
  - *Official* guidelines that journalists have to adhere to
  - lil and vague guidelines

    > "Avoid gender stereotypes and images that harm a person's dignity [...] Use proper and respectful language. Stick to the essential parts of the news and avoid spectacolarizing violence. Do not use terms that diminish the severity of the crime"

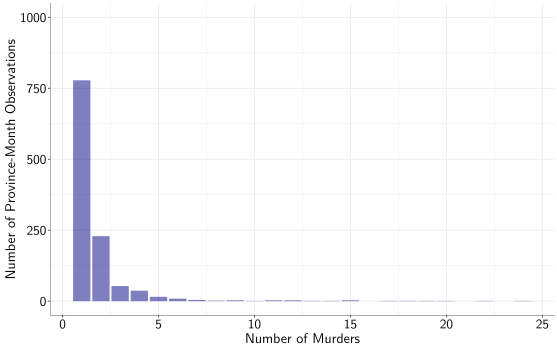
  - The Journalist Organization lacks ways to enforce its guidelines

Back

Distribution of Murders across Provinces-Months



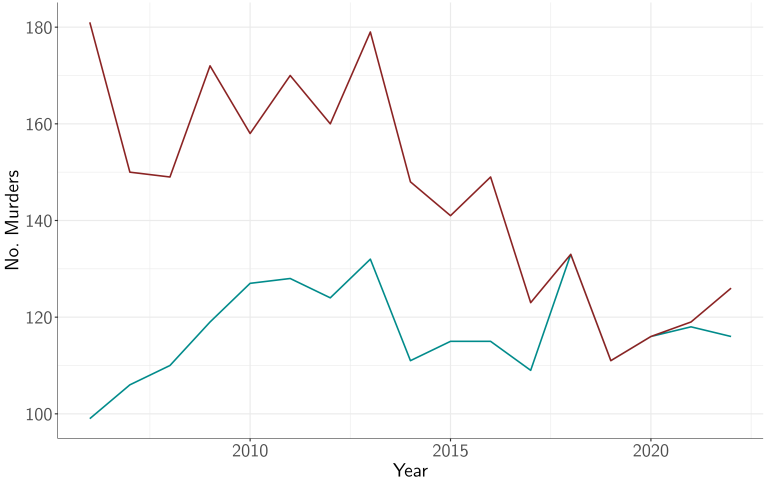
(a) Murders with Female Victims



(b) Murders with Male Victims

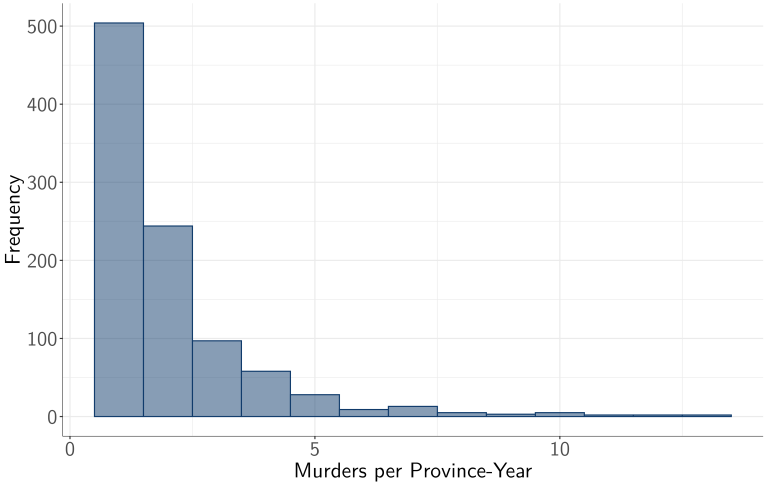
Back Back Data

Murders with Female Victims: Newspaper Coverage vs. ISTAT

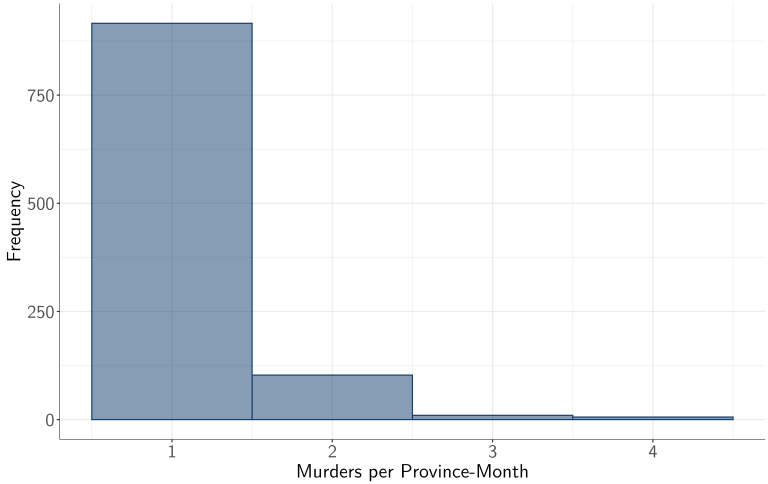


Back

Distribution of Murders in a Year



Distribution of Murders in a Month



Back Data Back

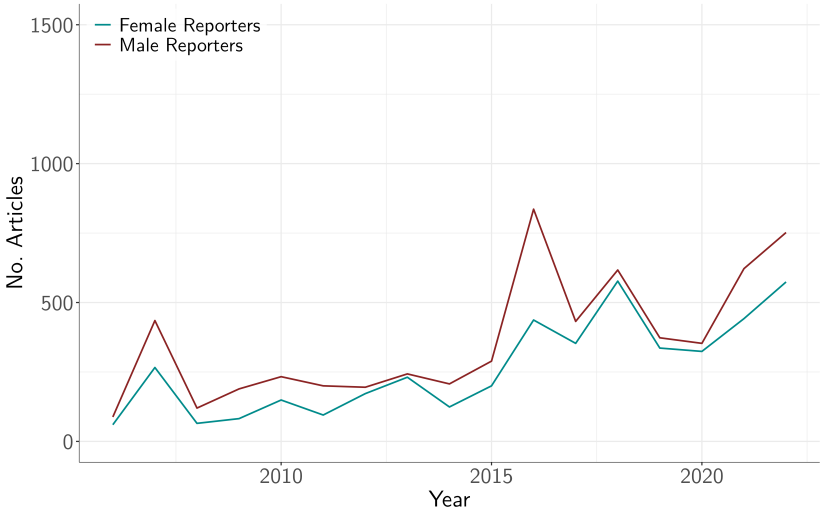
Summary Statistics: Murders

Summary Statistics: Murders

Variable	Mean	SD	N
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Victim Italian	0.77	0.42	1969
Perpetrator Italian	0.83	0.37	1860
Perpetrator Partner	0.66	0.47	1861
Perpetrator Relative	0.21	0.41	1861
Relationship Missing	0.06	0.25	1989
North	0.49	0.50	1989
South	0.30	0.46	1989
Center	0.21	0.41	1989

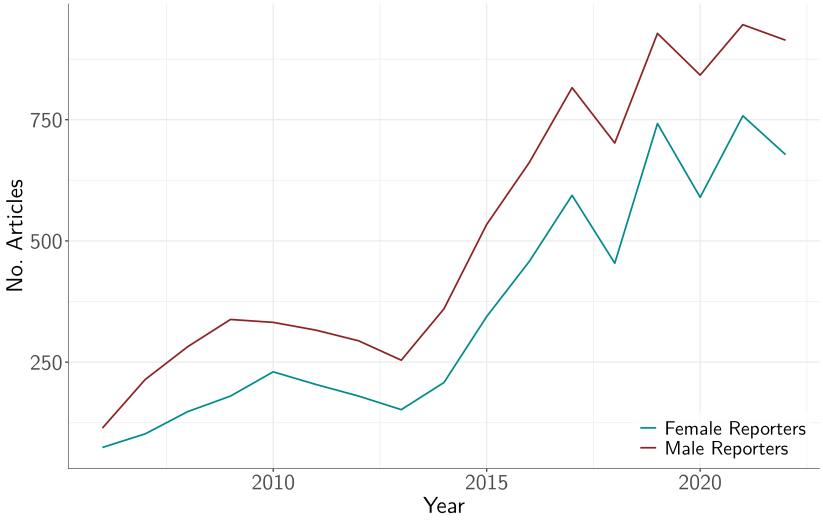
Back

Articles on Murders with Female Victims Over Time



Back

Articles on Murders with Male Victims Over Time



Back

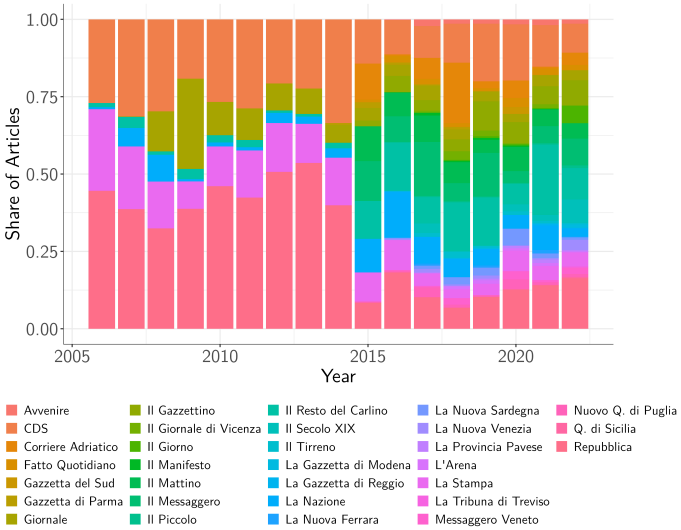
Summary Statistics: Reporters

Summary Statistics: Reporters

Variable	Mean	SD	N
Female	0.42	0.49	2355
Birth Year	1971.25	11.24	2034
Start Year	1999.79	11.01	2034
Professionista	0.73	0.44	2034
North	0.47	0.50	2034
South	0.19	0.39	2034
Center	0.34	0.47	2034
Liberal	0.50	0.50	2355
Conservative	0.35	0.48	2355

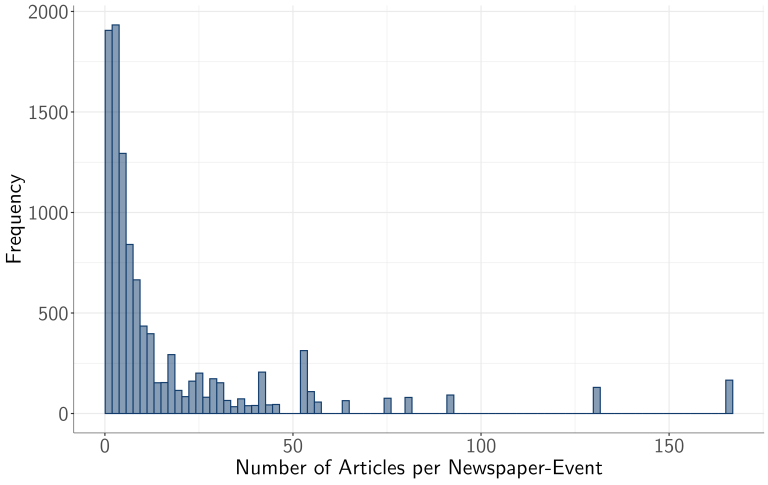
Back

Share of Articles for each Newspapers



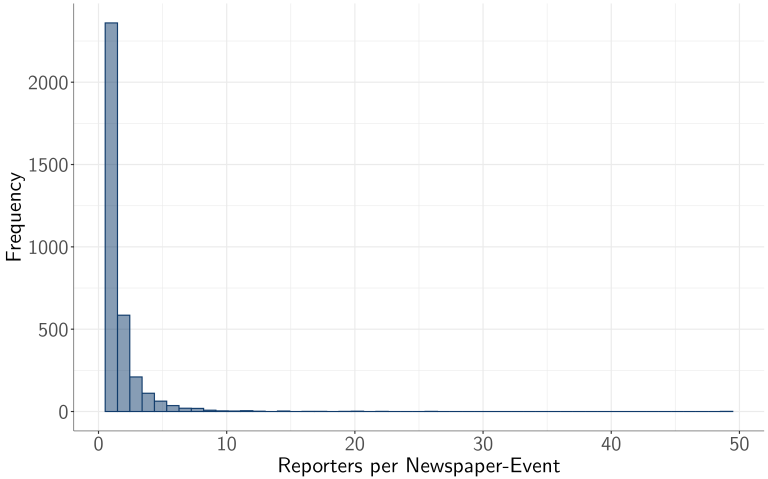
Back

Distribution of Articles per Newspaper-Event



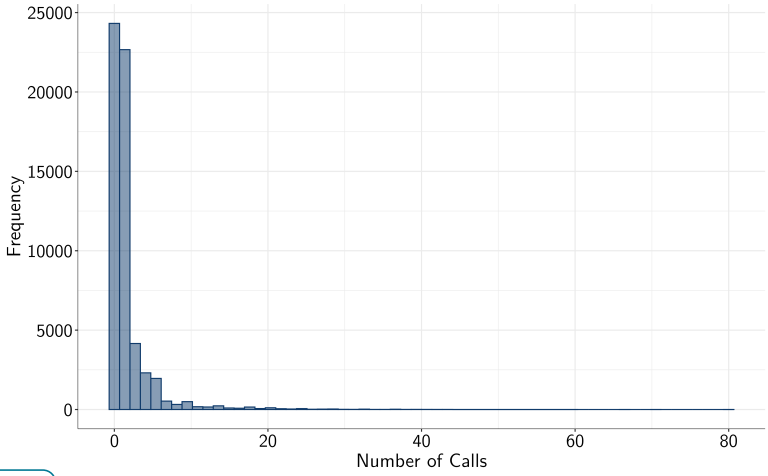
Back

Distribution of Reporters per Newspaper-Event



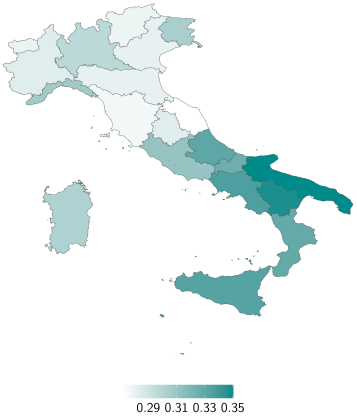
Back

Distribution of Calls



Back Data Back Calls

Share of Households with no Female Workers: 2019



Back

Dictionaries Validation

- Provide same task instructions to GPT and human annotators for 500 articles
- Dictionary approach is closer to human annotators than GPT
  - → the LLM over-infers the presence of some topic

Validation Keyword Approach

Topic	F1 Score		
	Dictionary-LLM (1)	Dictionary-Human (2)	Human-LLM (3)
Panel A: Perpetrator-Centered			
Mad Outburst	0.779	0.832	0.795
Jealousy	0.918	0.907	0.877
Econ. Difficulties	0.888	0.915	0.920
Mental Health Prob.	0.895	0.838	0.966
Infidelity	0.960	0.970	0.891
End of Relationship	0.860	0.861	0.867
Panel B: Victim-Centered			
Past Violence	0.856	0.900	0.842
Info on VAW Resources	0.954	0.955	0.945

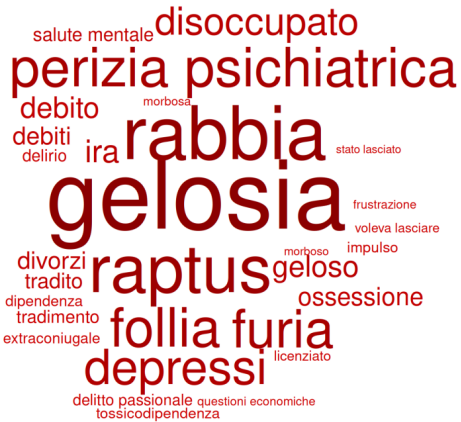
Back

Most Frequent Dictionary Words: Italian

(a) Victim-Centered

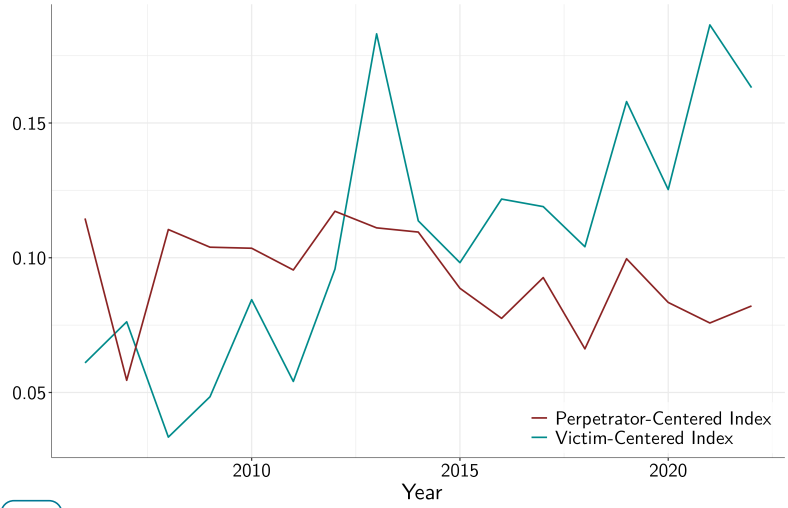


(b) Perpetrator-Centered



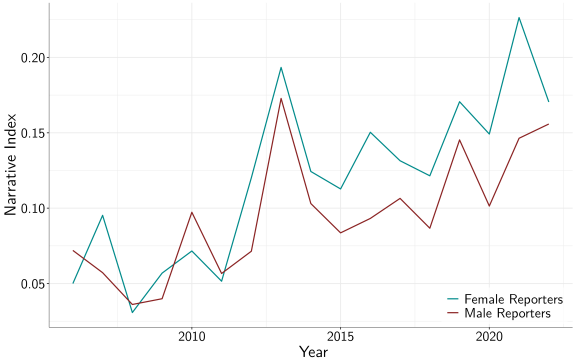
Back

Indexes over Time



Indexs by Gender
Back

Indexes by Reporters' Gender over Time



Victim-Centered Index



Perpetrator-Centered Index

Back

Journalists Assignment to Articles

1. News outlets receive the news from a news agency Example

Journalists Assignment to Articles

1. News outlets receive the news from a news agency Example
2. Section editors assign the article to reporters who are working and close to the event
   → For breaking news, like most crime news, newspaper need to be fast to write an article

Journalists Assignment to Articles

1. News outlets receive the news from a news agency Example
2. Section editors assign the article to reporters who are available and close to the event
3. Reporter writes an article using information from agencies and newspaper informants Example

Journalists Assignment to Articles

1. News outlets receive the news from a news agency Example
2. Section editors assign the article to reporters who are available and close to the event
3. Reporter writes an article using information from agencies and newspaper informants
4. Section editors check the article, assign a title, and publish it

Back

Example of ANSA Article

"Another murder of a woman, once again in her own apartment, has shaken Milan on a Sunday. **Rosanna Belvisi, 50, was found dead this afternoon in her apartment with a deep stab wound to the throat. The woman was found by her husband, who told investigators that he had gone out in the afternoon for a walk.** When he returned home, he allegedly found his wife lifeless and with her throat cut. At that point, around 3:00 p.m., he called emergency services (118), but the rescue efforts proved futile. [...] In the evening, the woman's husband and other residents of the building were taken to police headquarters to be questioned. [...] "The husband? A strange type, always dressed in black," said some residents of the neighborhood. **According to others, the couple—who had returned to Milan yesterday after a short vacation in Sicily—often argued. [...] Rosanna Belvisi was killed just three days after the murder of another woman [...]**"

Back

Example Article

"**Beaten to death by her husband in the bedroom with 23 stab wounds, after twenty years of violence and threats.** This is how the death of Rosanna Belvisi, 50, an INPS employee, unfolded in her 30-square-meter apartment. **The killer, Luigi Messina, 53, is a former security guard with minor prior offenses for resisting a public official and contempt of authority**. After denying everything for hours, **he confessed at 4 a.m. this morning, when the contradictions in his version of events became untenable.** [...] **At the center of the dispute was the man's illegitimate child, a three-year-old boy born to a lover and discovered by the wife only a few months ago.** [...] **It is the story of a woman who was left alone, without help to escape a life of terror. "The legal framework now exists," De Iesu recalled. "Victims of stalking must turn to anti-violence centers and inform the police headquarters, which have the power to issue formal warnings to violent men."** [...] The killing of Rosanna Belvisi is the second femicide in just a few days in Milan.[...]"

Back

Balance: Reporter Age

Variable	Old	Young	Difference in Means (with FE)		
	All	All	All	First Art.	Fifth Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Victim Italian	0.845	0.84	0.013	0.015	0.012
	(0.362)	(0.366)	(0.016)	(0.016)	(0.035)
Perpetrator Italian	0.799	0.787	-0.011	-0.004	-0.085***
	(0.401)	(0.41)	(0.022)	(0.014)	(0.029)
Perpetrator Partner	0.585	0.548	0.015	0.009	-0.039
	(0.493)	(0.498)	(0.016)	(0.02)	(0.052)
Perpetrator Relative	0.127	0.134	-0.004	-0.007	0.013
	(0.332)	(0.341)	(0.011)	(0.016)	(0.03)
Relationship Missing	0.137	0.139	0.016	0.02**	-0.005
	(0.343)	(0.346)	(0.015)	(0.009)	(0.037)
Crime >10 Articles	0.325	0.39	-0.015		
	(0.468)	(0.488)	(0.015)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.344	0.298	0.013		
	(0.475)	(0.457)	(0.013)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.584	0.621	-0.01		
	(0.493)	(0.485)	(0.024)		

Back

Balance: Reporter Experience

Variable	More Exp.	Less Exp.	Difference in Means (with FE)		
	All	All	All	First Art.	Fifth Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Victim Italian	0.848	0.837	0.011	0.011	0.049
	(0.359)	(0.369)	(0.009)	(0.019)	(0.043)
Perpetrator Italian	0.787	0.799	-0.023	-0.01	-0.098***
	(0.41)	(0.401)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.032)
Perpetrator Partner	0.579	0.552	0.014	0.008	-0.049*
	(0.494)	(0.497)	(0.018)	(0.02)	(0.027)
Perpetrator Relative	0.121	0.139	-0.008	-0.021	-0.018
	(0.327)	(0.346)	(0.007)	(0.014)	(0.038)
Relationship Missing	0.143	0.133	0.011	0.022	0.018
	(0.35)	(0.339)	(0.017)	(0.014)	(0.023)
Crime >10 Articles	0.324	0.393	-0.021		
	(0.468)	(0.488)	(0.012)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.343	0.297	0.016		
	(0.475)	(0.457)	(0.017)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.587	0.619	-0.002		
	(0.492)	(0.486)	(0.027)		

Back

Balance: Region Gender Norms

Variable	Traditional	Progressive	Difference in Means (with FE)		
	All	All	All	First Art.	Fifth Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Victim Italian	0.875	0.842	0.011	0.057***	0.008
	(0.331)	(0.365)	(0.043)	(0.007)	(0.104)
Perpetrator Italian	0.835	0.769	0.009	0.057***	0.001
	(0.371)	(0.422)	(0.029)	(0.011)	(0.031)
Perpetrator Partner	0.55	0.586	-0.076	-0.043	0.021
	(0.498)	(0.493)	(0.053)	(0.028)	(0.092)
Perpetrator Relative	0.112	0.116	0.002	0.034	-0.012
	(0.315)	(0.321)	(0.014)	(0.021)	(0.026)
Relationship Missing	0.157	0.139	0.062**	0.024**	0.038
	(0.364)	(0.346)	(0.028)	(0.01)	(0.054)
Crime >10 Articles	0.34	0.403	0.027		
	(0.474)	(0.491)	(0.057)		
First Article - Female Vict.	0.351	0.295	0.015		
	(0.477)	(0.456)	(0.035)		
First Article - Male Vict.	0.606	0.661	-0.05***		
	(0.489)	(0.474)	(0.016)		

Back

Results: At Least One Practice

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.056***	0.039***	0.046***	0.039***	−0.031**	−0.029**	−0.023*	−0.019
	(0.014)	(0.013)	(0.012)	(0.011)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.013)
Age				0.000				0.002***
				(0.001)				(0.001)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
Adj. R^2	0.004	0.066	0.077	0.288	0.001	0.036	0.039	0.187
Mean Index	0.287	0.287	0.287	0.287	0.382	0.382	0.382	0.382
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

Back

Results: Only First Articles

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Age	0.201***	0.155***	0.168***	−0.055	−0.016	−0.019
	(0.049)	(0.049)	(0.049)	(0.034)	(0.035)	(0.037)
Observations	3391	3391	3391	3391	3391	3391
R^2	0.008	0.174	0.187	0.001	0.100	0.110
Shr. Female Reporters	0.415	0.415	0.415	0.415	0.415	0.415
Newsp × Year FE		X	X		X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X			X

Back

Results: Controlling for Article Length

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.128***	0.132***	0.133***	−0.055**	−0.049**	−0.048**
	(0.025)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.023)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Article Length		0.001***			0.001***	
		(0.000)			(0.000)	
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.424	0.442	0.442	0.351	0.386	0.387
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Length-Decile FE			X			X

Back

Results: Unstandardized Index

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Female Reporter	0.036***	0.028**	0.031***	0.027***	−0.008*	−0.007*	−0.006+	−0.007*
	(0.007)	(0.006)	(0.006)	(0.005)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.003)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.007	0.118	0.130	0.424	0.001	0.058	0.064	0.351
Mean Index	0.122	0.122	0.122	0.122	0.086	0.086	0.086	0.086
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

Back

AKM Variance Decomposition

Share of Var(y)	VC (1)	PC (2)	VC ($\geq$5 arts.) (3)	PC ($\geq$5 arts.) (4)
Journalist var(α)	0.374	0.454	0.293	0.346
Outlet var(ψ)	0.184	0.305	0.224	0.247
Case var(κ)	0.470	0.432	0.483	0.432
Sorting 2cov(α, ψ)	-0.193	-0.441	-0.196	-0.318

Back

A Framework of Identity-Motivated Journalists

1. Journalists, like outlets, want to maximize readership

   Lindbeck and Weibull (1987), Mullainathan and Shleifer (2005), and Gentzkow and Shapiro (2006), (2010)

$\rightarrow$ Expect similar narratives within newspapers

Back

A Framework of Identity-Motivated Journalists

1. Journalists, like outlets, want to maximize readership

   Lindbeck and Weibull (1987), Mullainathan and Shleifer (2005), and Gentzkow and Shapiro (2006), (2010)

2. Journalists care about in-group readers, assuming
   - Narratives can benefit in-groups (*Part 2*)
   - Readers' preferences for narratives depend on their group (*Part 2*)

   Turner et al. (1979), Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004), and Miller and Segal (2019)

   $\rightarrow$ Potentially leads to systematic differences in narratives within newspapers

Back

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   Turner et al. (1979), Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004), and Miller and Segal (2019)

$\rightarrow$ Potentially leads to systematic differences in narratives within newspapers

Alternative Explanations

- Journalists from different group have different skills Ashraf et al. (2024)
- Journalists from different groups have different sources Baron (2006)
- Journalists want to promote their own ideology Boxell and Conway (2022) and Cage et al. (2025)

Back

The Model: Readers

Groups A (women) and B (men), of size $1-\rho$ and ρ. Narratives $s^{AN} > s^{BN}$.

Reader i's utility from an article with narrative s_j

$$U_i(s_j) = \underbrace{-|s_j - \hat{s}_i|}_{\text{taste}} + \underbrace{\phi_i(s_j)}_{\text{indirect effect}}$$

Back

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Taste. $\hat{s}_i$ is stochastic and group-specific:

$$\mathrm{P}\big(\hat{s}_i = s^{AN} \mid i = A\big) = \alpha_A, \quad \mathrm{P}\big(\hat{s}_i = s^{AN} \mid i = B\big) = \alpha_B, \quad \alpha_A > \tfrac{1}{2} > \alpha_B$$

Back

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Indirect effect. Readers gain from the narrative favouring their group, $\tau > 0$ (Akerlof and Kranton, 2000):

$$\phi_A(s^{AN}) = \phi_B(s^{BN}) = \tau \quad \text{and} \quad \phi_A(s^{BN}) = \phi_B(s^{AN}) = -\tau$$

Back

The Model: Journalists

Journalist j chooses $s_j \in \{s^{AN}, s^{BN}\}$ to maximise

$$W_j(s_j) = \underbrace{\iota_j[\rho\,\mathrm{P}(U_B(s_j) \geq U_B(s_{-j})) + (1-\rho)\,\mathrm{P}(U_A(s_j) \geq U_A(s_{-j}))]}_{\text{monetary return: how many readers read}} + \underbrace{(1-\iota_j)\,\mathbb{E}[U_{i=j}(s_j)]}_{\text{altruism: welfare of own-group readers}}$$

Back

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$\iota_j \in [0,1]$ is the weight on readership: $\iota_j = 1$ is a purely commercial journalist, $\iota_j < 1$ an *identity-motivated* one.

Back

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$\iota_j \in [0,1]$ is the weight on readership: $\iota_j = 1$ is a purely commercial journalist, $\iota_j < 1$ an *identity-motivated* one.

Choosing s^{BN} over s^{AN} requires $W_j(s^{BN}) \geq W_j(s^{AN})$:

$$DR_j(s^{BN}) = \begin{cases} \iota_A(2\rho-1) + (1-\iota_A)\left[(1-2\alpha_A)(s^{AN}-s^{BN}) - 2\tau\right] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = A \\ \iota_B(2\rho-1) + (1-\iota_B)\left[(1-2\alpha_B)(s^{AN}-s^{BN}) + 2\tau\right] \geq 0 & \text{if } j = B \end{cases}$$

The monetary term $(2\rho-1)$ is common to both groups — they face the same readership. Only the altruistic term differs. Baseline assumes $\tau \geq \frac{s^{AN}-s^{BN}}{2}$, so the indirect effect dominates taste.

Back

The Model: Predictions

Proposition 1 (Purely commercial journalists)
*If $\iota_A = \iota_B = 1$, both groups face the **same** decision rule, and $s_A^* = s_B^* = s^{BN}$ if $\rho \geq \frac{1}{2}$ (and s^{AN} otherwise).*

→ **Observing different narratives across groups implies at least one group is identity-motivated.**

Back

The Model: Predictions

Proposition 1 (Purely commercial journalists)
*If $\iota_A = \iota_B = 1$, both groups face the **same** decision rule, and $s_A^* = s_B^* = s^{BN}$ if $\rho \geq \frac{1}{2}$ (and s^{AN} otherwise).*

→ **Observing different narratives across groups implies at least one group is identity-motivated.**

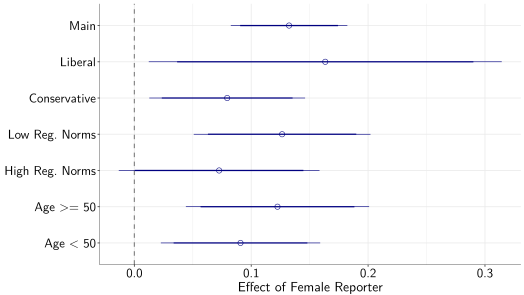
Proposition 2 (Identity-motivated journalists)
If $\iota_A < 1$ or $\iota_B < 1$, then $(s_A^*, s_B^*) = (s^{AN}, s^{BN})$ if and only if

- $\rho \leq \frac{1}{2}$ *and* $\dfrac{2(1-\alpha_B)(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{1-2\rho} \geq \dfrac{\iota_B}{1-\iota_B}$, *or*
- $\rho \geq \frac{1}{2}$ *and* $\dfrac{2\alpha_A(s^{AN} - s^{BN})}{2\rho - 1} \geq \dfrac{\iota_A}{1-\iota_A}$

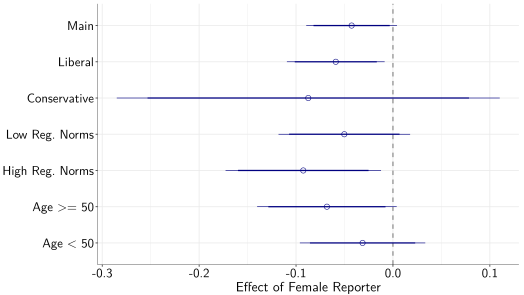
→ Journalists write for their in-group when it is the **majority of readers**, when they **care enough** about it (ι low), or when its preferred narrative also **benefits** it (α_A high, α_B low).

Back

Gender Effect Within Groups



(c) Standardized Victim-Centered Index



(d) Standardized Perpetrator-Centered Index

Back

Age differences in reporting

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Age<50	−0.015	−0.056*	−0.041	−0.019	−0.040	−0.018	−0.027	−0.046*
	(0.032)	(0.030)	(0.031)	(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.026)
Female Reporter				0.131***				−0.048**
				(0.026)				(0.024)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.000	0.115	0.126	0.424	0.000	0.057	0.063	0.351
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X	X			X	X
Crime FE				X				X

Back

Differences in reporting along gender norms

	Reporting Narrative							
	Victim-Centered Index				Perpetrator-Centered Index			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Reg. Norms	1.493*	0.859	−2.919***	−2.647***	1.746**	2.062**	0.588	0.375
	(0.863)	(0.917)	(0.897)	(0.903)	(0.802)	(0.950)	(1.002)	(1.016)
Female Reporter				0.120***				−0.069***
				(0.030)				(0.026)
Age				0.003*				0.006***
				(0.001)				(0.001)
Observations	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731	7731
R^2	0.005	0.109	0.410	0.413	0.005	0.066	0.371	0.373
Shr. Female Reporters	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423	0.423
Newsp × Year FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X			X	X

Back

Differences in reporting along newspapers ideology

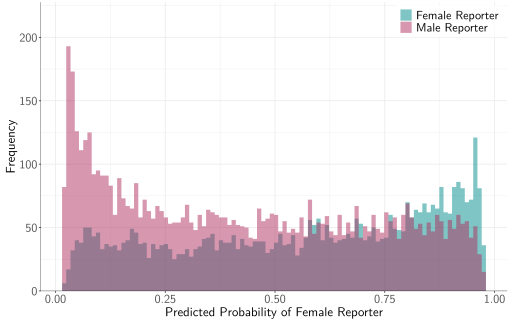
	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Liberal	0.053	0.083**	0.127**	0.016	−0.037	−0.038
	(0.055)	(0.042)	(0.056)	(0.056)	(0.025)	(0.027)
Female Reporter			0.137**			−0.054**
			(0.056)			(0.026)
Age			−0.001			−0.003**
			(0.002)			(0.001)
Observations	9048	9048	9048	9048	9048	9048
R^2	0.001	0.412	0.422	0.000	0.337	0.341
Shr. Female Reporters	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409	0.409
Crime FE		X	X		X	X
Year FE		X	X		X	X
Reporter Reg. FE			X			X

Back

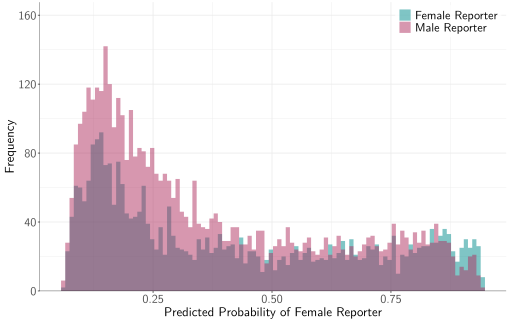
Do Male and Female Reporters Write Differently?

- Train a BERT classifier to predict author's gender from the article text
- The model is able to predict gender in art. with female victims but not in art. with male victims

Female victims



Male victims



Classifier Performance | Female vs. Male Predicted Articles | Back | Back Robustness

Classification Metrics by Victim's Gender

Classification Metrics BERT

Metric	Female Victims	Male Victims
Accuracy	0.595	0.574
F1 Score	0.597	0.418
Precision	0.517	0.472
Recall	0.601	0.375

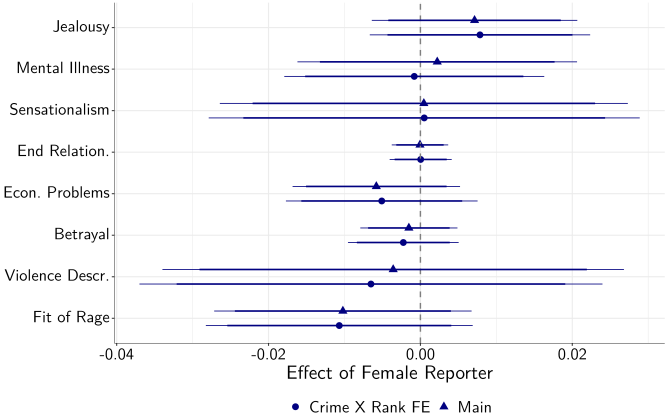
Back

Female Predicted vs. Male Predicted Article

P(Female)=0.97	P(Female)=0.02
Since the beginning of the year, there have been 47 cases of femicide in Italy. Women killed by those who claimed to love them—because of a no, a rejection, because the end of a relationship was not accepted. Killed, in most cases, by partners, husbands, or boyfriends. The case of Sonia Lattari, a 43-year-old woman killed by her husband in Fagnano, in the province of Cosenza, is just one of the most recent cases in a list that is already far too long. Relations between the two reportedly had been tense for some time, but just a few hours ago, Servidio's resentment toward his wife erupted into brutal violence. The couple had two children and, after spending a period in Corsica for work reasons, had returned some years ago to their hometown.	He was 61 years old, a former entrepreneur in the petroleum sector; she was 33, the mother of a six-year-old child, and worked as a shop assistant in a bakery. Theirs was a stormy relationship, marked by arguments and temporary separations. Then she had had enough and ended it for good. He had never come to terms with it and had tried repeatedly to find her, begging her to come back to him. They had been seen together on Sunday in Varazze, riding in his SUV. He fired at least four shots at her, hitting her in the back of the neck and in one arm. He could not accept the idea that the young woman—who was half his age—no longer wanted anything to do with him.

Back

Gender Differences in Reporting about Murders with Male Victims



Back

No Gender Differences in Writing Quality

	Reporting Quality Metric					
	Gulpease	Lexical Div.	Words/Sent.	Length	No. Sources	Source Div.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.200	0.103	−0.154	7.095	0.015	0.014
	(0.169)	(0.769)	(0.163)	(5.478)	(0.025)	(0.029)
Observations	10288	10256	10288	10288	10587	10587
R^2	0.157	0.159	0.161	0.229	0.221	0.221
Mean Dep. Var.	53.600	164.948	20.883	453.030	0.752	0.838
Shr. Female Reporters	0.422	0.422	0.422	0.422	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Reporter Specialization in VAW Coverage

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered			Perpetrator-Centered		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.128***	0.127***	0.127***	−0.055**	−0.054**	−0.053**
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.023)	(0.024)	(0.024)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.424	0.425	0.424	0.351	0.351	0.351
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
VAW Spec. Control	–	Total	Prior	–	Total	Prior

Back

Reporter Specialization in VAW Coverage

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered			Perpetrator-Centered		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.135***	0.095***	0.100***	−0.001	−0.065**	−0.058*
	(0.050)	(0.031)	(0.035)	(0.043)	(0.029)	(0.031)
Observations	2677	7910	6210	2677	7910	6210
R^2	0.585	0.469	0.506	0.550	0.392	0.432
Shr. Female Reporters	0.435	0.416	0.405	0.435	0.416	0.405
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Prev. VAW Arts.	<5	≥5	≥10	<5	≥5	≥10

Back

Lower Editorial Oversight: Weekend Editions

	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
Sample	Weekday	Weekend	Weekday	Weekend
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Female Reporter	0.111***	0.212***	−0.028	−0.105**
	(0.028)	(0.049)	(0.027)	(0.043)
Observations	8072	2515	8072	2515
R^2	0.447	0.563	0.384	0.526
Shr. Female Reporters	0.425	0.406	0.425	0.406
Crime FE	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X

Back

The Role of Editors: Desk-Editor Gender

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Index			Perpetrator-Centered Index		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Desk Editor	−0.064	0.116	0.171	−0.205*	0.044	−0.013
	(0.147)	(0.157)	(0.200)	(0.107)	(0.147)	(0.157)
Observations	9911	9911	9911	9911	9911	9911
R^2	0.000	0.087	0.378	0.002	0.042	0.309
Shr. Female Editor	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043	0.043
Newsp × Year FE		X	X		X	X
Crime FE			X			X

Back

Differential Sourcing

	Police	Judiciary	Family	Neighbours	Lawyer
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Female reporter	−0.017	−0.008	0.013	−0.002	0.029***
	(0.011)	(0.007)	(0.010)	(0.009)	(0.008)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.225	0.179	0.222	0.209	0.181
Mean Dep. Var.	0.216	0.102	0.193	0.141	0.100
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Differential Sourcing

	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Female reporter	0.128***	0.131***	−0.055**	−0.056**
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.023)	(0.023)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.424	0.426	0.351	0.360
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Source controls		X		X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X
Reporter Region FE	X	X	X	X
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X

Back

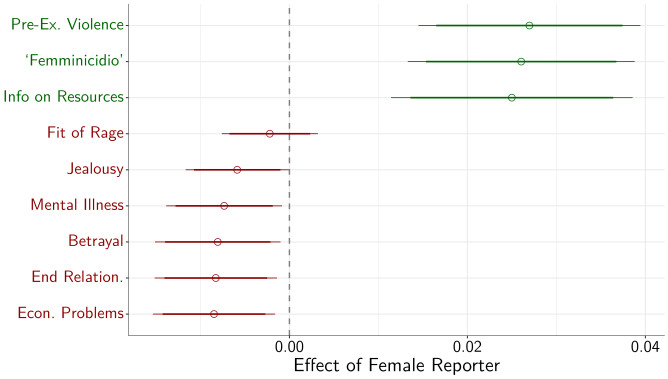
Robustness

- Robust to dropping one dimension at a time Dropping Topics
- Control for articles' order of publication
- Crime times newspaper fixed effects
- Weight for the popularity of articles
- Restrict the sample to first article
- Restrict to 5 days following the first article
- Exclude crimes with more than 10 article per newspaper
- Restrict to intimate partner violence
- Restrict to Italian perpetrators
- Bylines do not select which articles enter the sample

Alternative Regression Specifications | Alternative Sample Specifications | Byline Selection | Signed Articles

Back

Dropping one Dimension at a time



Back

Results Victim-Centered Index: Alternative Specifications

	Victim-Centered Index				
	Art. Order× Crime FE	Crime× Newsp FE	Crime× Year Clust.	Crime× Auth. Clust.	Weighted
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Female Reporter	0.125***	0.123***	0.128***	0.128***	0.142***
	(0.028)	(0.030)	(0.024)	(0.024)	(0.033)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.362	0.587	0.424	0.424	0.575
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X	X

Back

Results Perpetrator-Centered Index: Alternative Specifications

	Perpetrator-Centered Index				
	Art. Order× Crime FE	Crime× Newsp FE	Crime× Year Clust.	Crime× Auth. Clust.	Weighted
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Female Reporter	−0.044*	−0.065**	−0.055**	−0.055**	−0.032
	(0.025)	(0.029)	(0.022)	(0.023)	(0.030)
Observations	10587	10587	10587	10587	10587
R^2	0.314	0.520	0.351	0.351	0.508
Shr. Female Reporters	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420	0.420
Newsp × Year FE	X		X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE			X	X	X

Back

Results Victim-Centered Index: Alternative Samples

	Victim-Centered Index					
	First Art.	First 5 Art.	IPV	Italian Perp.	No Viral Events	All Crimes Rep.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	0.156***	0.118***	0.160***	0.127***	0.135***	0.063*
	(0.046)	(0.031)	(0.039)	(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.035)
Observations	3391	7004	6006	8045	6577	6804
R^2	0.646	0.486	0.447	0.456	0.499	0.476
Shr. Female Reporters	0.415	0.426	0.415	0.414	0.433	0.394
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Results Perpetrator-Centered Index: Alternative Samples

	Perpetrator-Centered Index					
	First Art.	First 5 Art.	IPV	Italian Perp.	No Viral Events	All Crimes Rep.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Reporter	−0.056	−0.058*	−0.066**	−0.067**	−0.059*	−0.091***
	(0.039)	(0.031)	(0.029)	(0.028)	(0.031)	(0.031)
Observations	3391	7004	6006	8045	6577	6804
R^2	0.610	0.414	0.346	0.348	0.413	0.418
Shr. Female Reporters	0.415	0.426	0.415	0.414	0.433	0.394
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Reporter Reg. FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Crime FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Byline Selection: What Predicts Signing?

	Article is Signed (Bylined)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Article Length (100 words)	0.040***	0.040***	0.039**	0.041***
	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.014)	(0.012)
Perp. is Partner		−0.004	−0.007	0.004
		(0.013)	(0.014)	(0.013)
Perp. is Relative		0.003	−0.002	0.004
		(0.010)	(0.012)	(0.014)
Victim Italian			−0.009	−0.013
			(0.013)	(0.013)
Perp. Italian			0.007	0.017
			(0.013)	(0.011)
Observations	27155	27155	26070	26070
R^2	0.253	0.253	0.252	0.263
Shr. Signed Articles	0.396	0.396	0.396	0.396
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X
Crime Region FE				X

Back

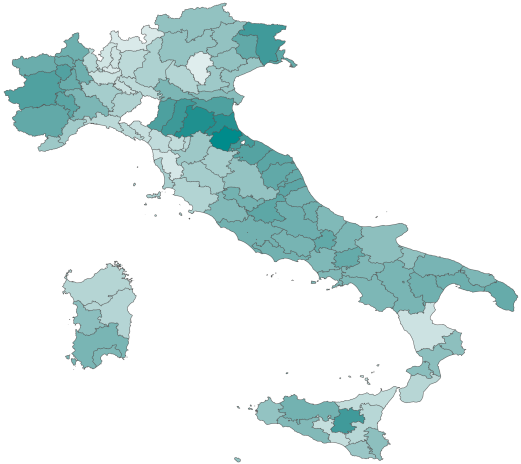
Byline Selection: Signed Articles and Sample Composition

- Signed articles use slightly more of both narratives
- Bylines are evenly distributed across man and women

	Reporting Narrative			
	Victim-Centered Index		Perpetrator-Centered Index	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Signed (Bylined)	0.033***	0.010**	0.031***	0.015***
	(0.005)	(0.004)	(0.003)	(0.002)
Observations	27155	27155	27155	27155
R^2	0.083	0.117	0.055	0.107
Newsp × Year FE	X	X	X	X
Length Control		X		X

Back

Distribution of Female Exposure Measure across Provinces



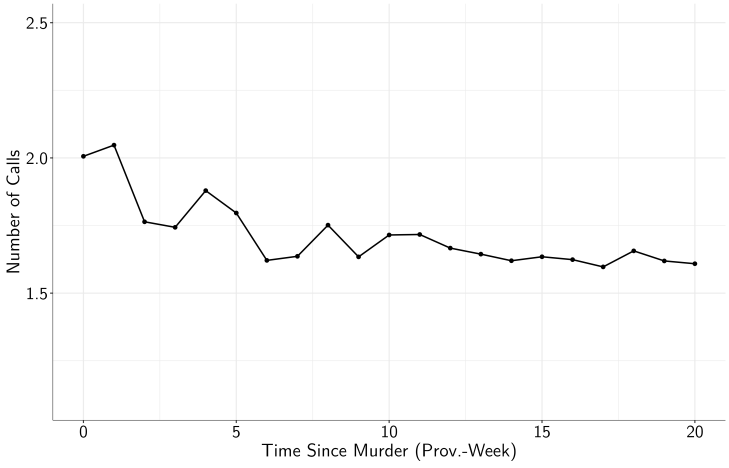
Back

Distribution of Calls across Provinces



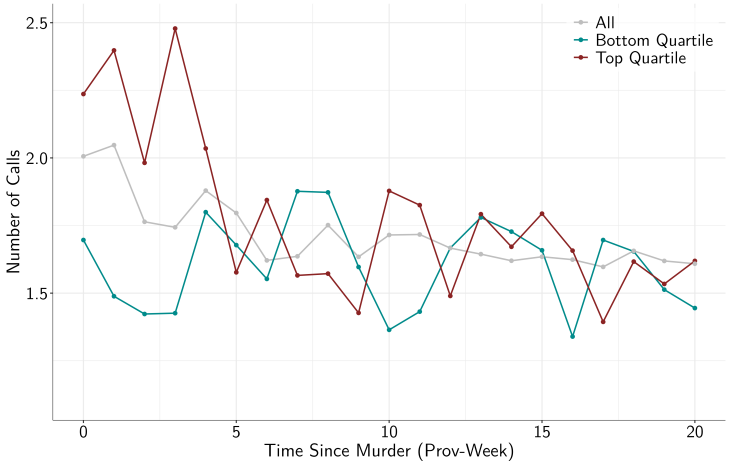
Back

Residualized Calls over Time after Murder: Female Victims



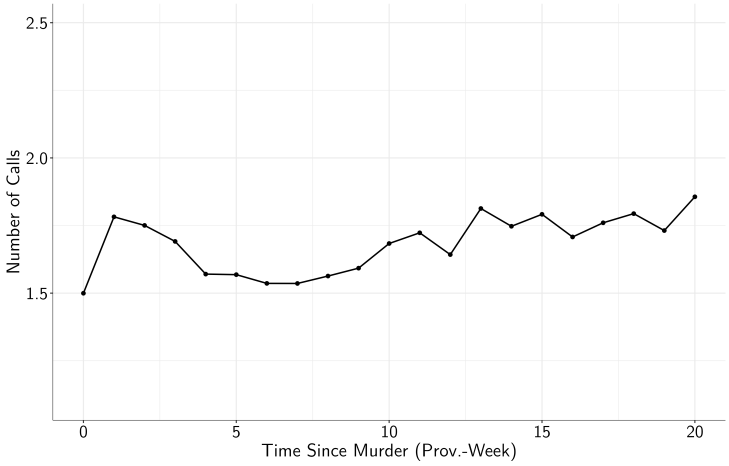
Back

Residualized Calls over Time after Murder: Female Victims



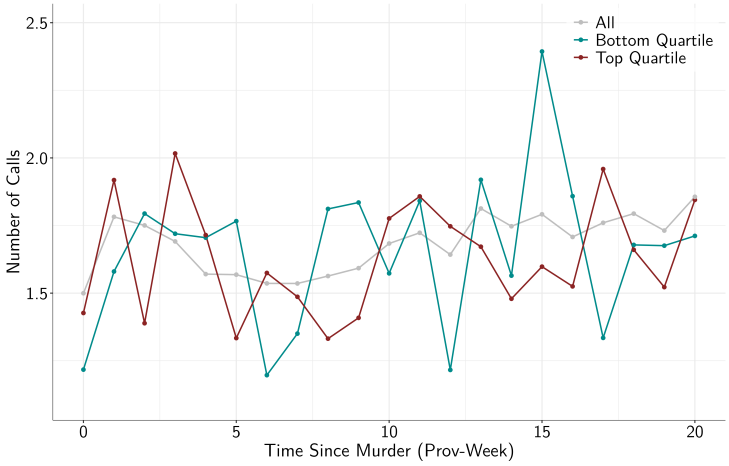
Back

Residualized Calls over Time after Murder: Male Victims



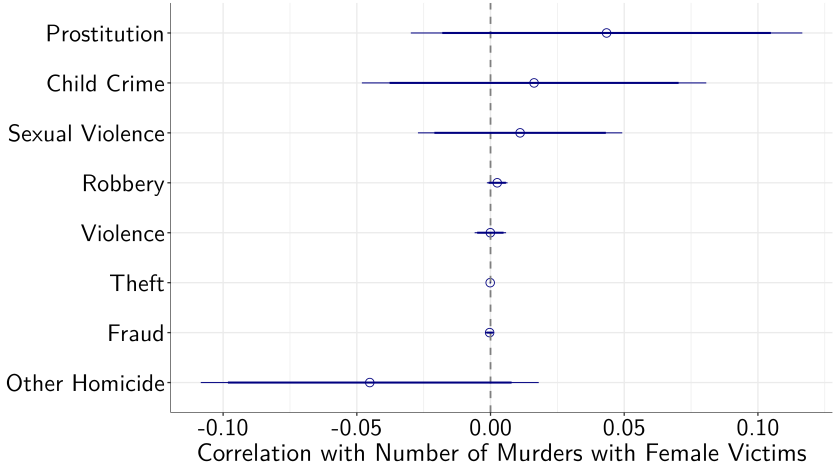
Back

Residualized Calls over Time after Murder: Male Victims



Back

Correlation Between Female Murders and Crime Rates



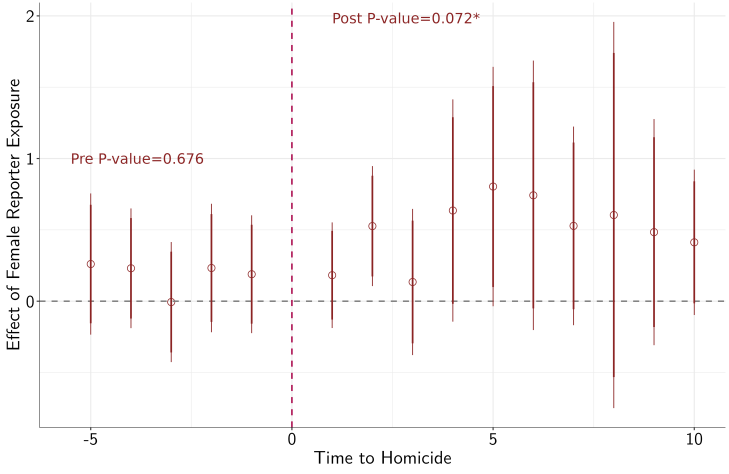
Back

Results: Difference-in-Differences

	At Least 1 Call				Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	0.106	0.116*	0.116*	0.140*	0.246	0.302*	0.302*	0.426
	(0.068)	(0.067)	(0.067)	(0.072)	(0.177)	(0.183)	(0.181)	(0.299)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art}	−0.047	−0.083	−0.083		−0.078	−0.271	−0.270	
	(0.059)	(0.057)	(0.057)		(0.187)	(0.168)	(0.167)	
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6905
R^2	0.268	0.282	0.282	0.393	0.535	0.564	0.564	0.567
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Expl. Var.	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE		X	X	X		X	X	X
Crime FE				X				X

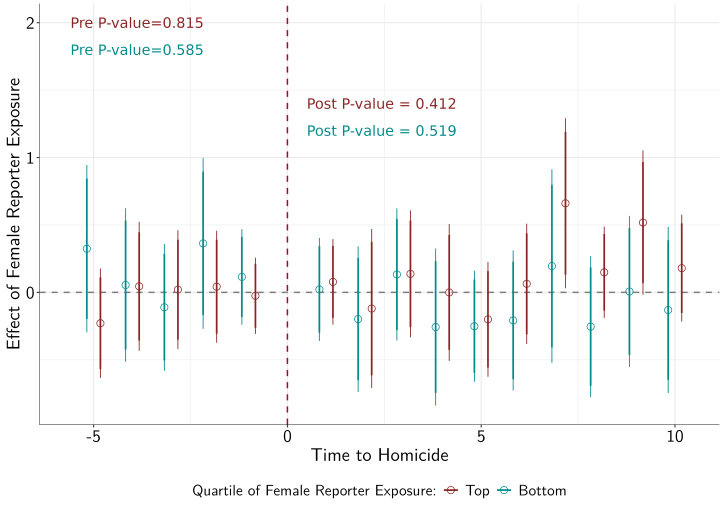
Back

Event Study: Continuous Treatment



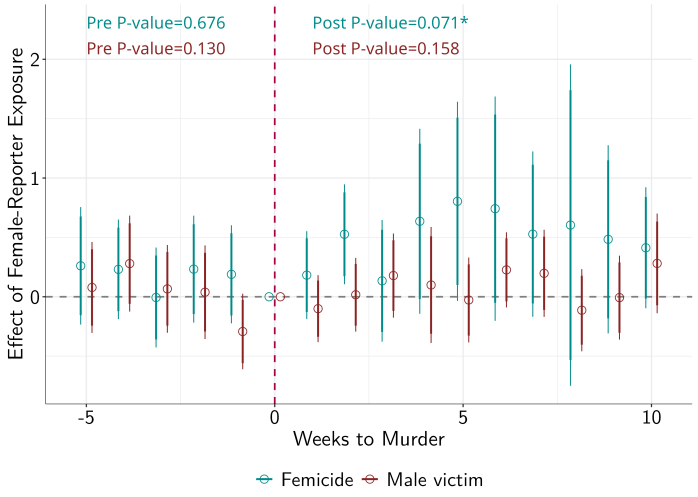
Back Back Robustness

Event Study: Murders with Male Victims



Back | Back Robustness

Triple Difference: Calls by Victim Gender



Back

Triple Difference: Calls by Victim Gender

	Number of Calls (Poisson)					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure× Post	0.057	−0.077	−0.022	−0.050	−0.039	−0.037
	(0.080)	(0.100)	(0.096)	(0.112)	(0.118)	(0.153)
Fem. Exposure× Post × Female Victim	0.239	0.372	0.321*	0.351**	0.337*	0.328
	(0.186)	(0.237)	(0.181)	(0.170)	(0.195)	(0.209)
Observations	14911	13766	13377	13062	12809	11983
R^2	0.574	0.548	0.541	0.533	0.531	0.529
Mean Dep. Var.	3.601	3.226	3.125	3.025	2.991	2.941
Mean Treatment	0.246	0.244	0.242	0.241	0.241	0.239
Male-victim murders dropped	None	±2 wks	±3 wks	±4 wks	±5 wks	±8 wks
Male-victim events	1401	1161	1080	1010	959	815
Province, Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Rel. time × Victim gender FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

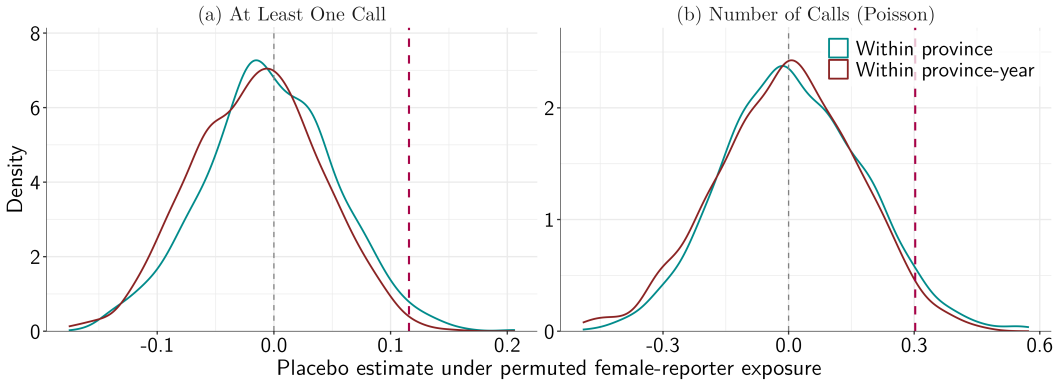
Back

Timing Placebo: Male Murders Preceding a Femicide

	At Least 1 Call			Number of Calls (Poisson)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	−0.204	0.057	0.167	0.638	−0.116	0.107
	(0.182)	(0.126)	(0.107)	(0.544)	(0.336)	(0.288)
Observations	239	459	702	239	457	700
R^2	0.494	0.381	0.377	0.580	0.553	0.572
Mean Dep. Var.	0.866	0.871	0.859	9.498	8.947	8.076
Mean Treatment	0.262	0.288	0.285	0.262	0.289	0.285
Male murder before femicide	≤1 wk	≤2 wks	≤3 wks	≤1 wk	≤2 wks	≤3 wks
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

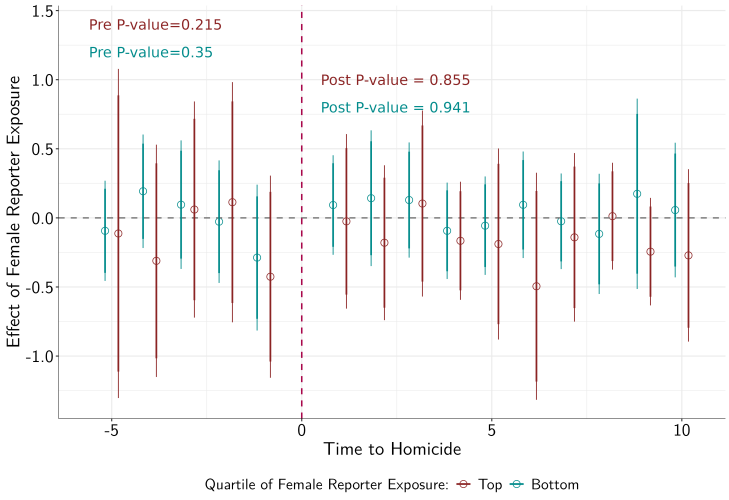
Back

Randomization Inference: Permuted Exposure Shares



Back

Event Study: Placebo Events



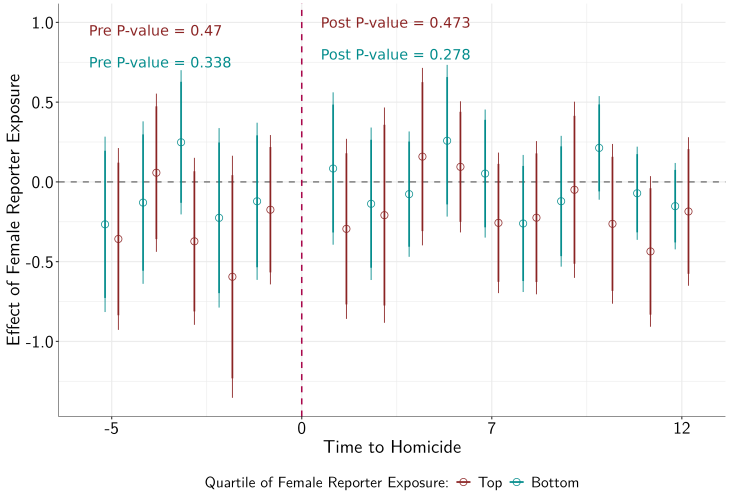
Back

Balance Check Treatment

Variable	Average		Difference in Means	
	High Exposure (1)	Low Exposure (2)	Without FE (3)	With Year FE (4)
Perp. is Partner	0.615	0.646	-0.032	-0.030
	(0.487)	(0.479)	(0.028)	(0.029)
Perp. is Relative	0.185	0.181	0.005	0.008
	(0.389)	(0.385)	(0.021)	(0.022)
Victim Italian	0.800	0.783	0.017	0.029
	(0.400)	(0.413)	(0.024)	(0.026)
Perp. Italian	0.851	0.840	0.011	0.009
	(0.356)	(0.367)	(0.022)	(0.023)
Homicides (prov-week)	0.102	0.082	0.019	0.010
	(0.560)	(0.310)	(0.018)	(0.017)

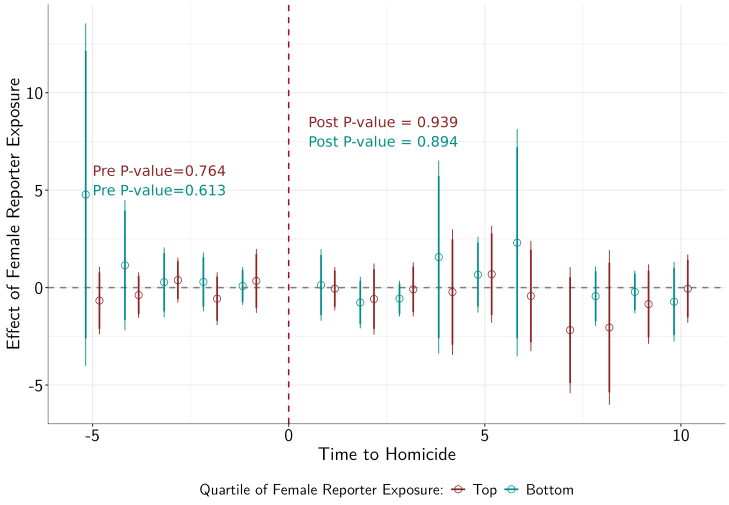
Back

Event Study: Total Number of Articles



Back

Event Study: Neighboring Provinces



Back

Effect of Female Rep. on Calls: Alternative Specifications

	At Least 1 Call				Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art}	−0.083	−0.084	−0.083	−0.088	−0.288	−0.269*	−0.272	−0.270
	(0.055)	(0.056)	(0.056)	(0.057)	(0.191)	(0.163)	(0.167)	(0.177)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	0.120*	0.116*	0.115*	0.114*	0.291	0.308*	0.305*	0.299
	(0.067)	(0.067)	(0.067)	(0.067)	(0.207)	(0.185)	(0.181)	(0.185)
Murders in Province-Year		−0.000				0.005		
		(0.003)				(0.008)		
Crime Female Rep.			−0.007				−0.011	
			(0.006)				(0.012)	
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6924	6980	6980	6980	6924
R^2	0.284	0.282	0.283	0.279	0.568	0.564	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Gender Norms×Year FE		X				X		
Other Crime Rates				X				X

Back

Different Number of Articles: Number of Calls

	Poisson Model					Zero-Infl. Poisson
Articles	Main	1 Art.	2 Art.	3 Art.	4 Art.	5 Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure^{XArt} × Post	0.302*	0.019	0.125	0.213	0.261	0.299***
	(0.181)	(0.156)	(0.169)	(0.197)	(0.194)	(0.084)
Fem. Exposure^{XArt}	−0.270	−0.111	−0.132	−0.217	−0.280*	−0.270***
	(0.167)	(0.147)	(0.150)	(0.173)	(0.166)	(0.072)
Observations	6980	6969	6980	6980	6980	6980
R^2	0.564	0.562	0.563	0.564	0.564	
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.166	0.188	0.198	0.204	0.208
Gender Norms Control	X	X	X	X	X	X
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Different Number of Articles: At Least One Call

	At Least One Call				
Articles	Main	1 Art.	2 Art.	3 Art.	4 Art.
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Fem. Exposure^{XArt}	−0.083	−0.027	−0.048	−0.064	−0.085*
	(0.057)	(0.043)	(0.043)	(0.048)	(0.049)
Fem. Exposure^{XArt} X Post	0.116*	0.068	0.079	0.106*	0.103*
	(0.067)	(0.053)	(0.055)	(0.061)	(0.062)
Observations	6980	6969	6980	6980	6980
R^2	0.282	0.282	0.282	0.282	0.282
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741	0.741
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.166	0.188	0.198	0.204
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X	X

Back

Trimming the Treatment Distribution

	At Least 1 Call				Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art}	−0.083	−0.105	−0.083	−0.244	−0.270	−0.284***	−0.418**	−0.657***
	(0.057)	(0.072)	(0.086)	(0.149)	(0.167)	(0.102)	(0.207)	(0.232)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	0.116*	0.118	0.093	0.347*	0.302*	0.317***	0.600***	0.703**
	(0.067)	(0.087)	(0.105)	(0.187)	(0.181)	(0.090)	(0.217)	(0.297)
Observations	6980	6264	5594	4181	6980	6264	5594	4181
R^2	0.282	0.281	0.288	0.312	0.564	0.561	0.558	0.552
Mean Dep. Var.	0.741	0.744	0.745	0.741	3.668	3.683	3.671	3.647
Dose trimmed	None (baseline)	5% each tail	10% each tail	20% each tail	None (baseline)	5% each tail	10% each tail	20% each tail
Events retained	1108	996	886	664	1108	996	886	664
Province, Window, Month FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Crime (event) FE								

Back

Effect of Each Victim-Centered Component

	Number of Calls (Poisson)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Pre-Violence^{5Art}	-0.208^{**}			-0.279^{***}
	(0.105)			(0.097)
Pre-Violence^{5Art} × Post	0.260^{***}			0.250^{**}
	(0.100)			(0.098)
Femicide Label^{5Art}		0.217^{***}		0.244^{***}
		(0.069)		(0.074)
Femicide Label^{5Art} × Post		-0.052		-0.119
		(0.143)		(0.127)
Help Info^{5Art}			0.163	0.127
			(0.137)	(0.159)
Help Info^{5Art} × Post			0.239	0.208
			(0.217)	(0.185)
Observations	6939	6939	6939	6939
R^2	0.563	0.563	0.563	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.202	0.188	0.039	–
Province FE	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X
Month FE	X	X	X	X

Back

Effect of Female-Reporters Exposure on Narratives

	Reporting Narrative					
	Victim-Centered Narratives			Perpetrator-Centered Narratives		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Female Rep. Exposure	0.087***	0.061***	0.061***	−0.022	−0.077***	−0.077***
	(0.020)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.016)	(0.017)	(0.017)
Region Gender Norms			−0.176			0.110
			(0.296)			(0.348)
Observations	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443	56443
R^2	0.000	0.054	0.054	0.000	0.013	0.013
Mean Dep. Var.	0.147	0.147	0.147	0.097	0.097	0.097
Mean Treatment	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208	0.208
Province FE		X	X		X	X
Month FE		X	X		X	X

Back

Effect of Female-Reporters Exposure on Helpline Calls: Different Narratives

	Number of Calls (Poisson)					
	Articles with No VC Narratives			Articles with VC Narratives		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art} × Post	0.081	0.201	0.201	0.511*	0.453*	0.454*
	(0.261)	(0.301)	(0.299)	(0.270)	(0.237)	(0.237)
Fem. Exposure^{5Art}	−0.293	−0.310	−0.309	0.519*	−0.098	−0.098
	(0.229)	(0.207)	(0.206)	(0.309)	(0.261)	(0.260)
Observations	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980	6980
R^2	0.536	0.564	0.564	0.538	0.564	0.564
Mean Dep. Var.	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668	3.668
Mean Treatment	0.142	0.142	0.142	0.066	0.066	0.066
Province FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Window FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Month FE		X	X		X	X
Gender Norms			X			X

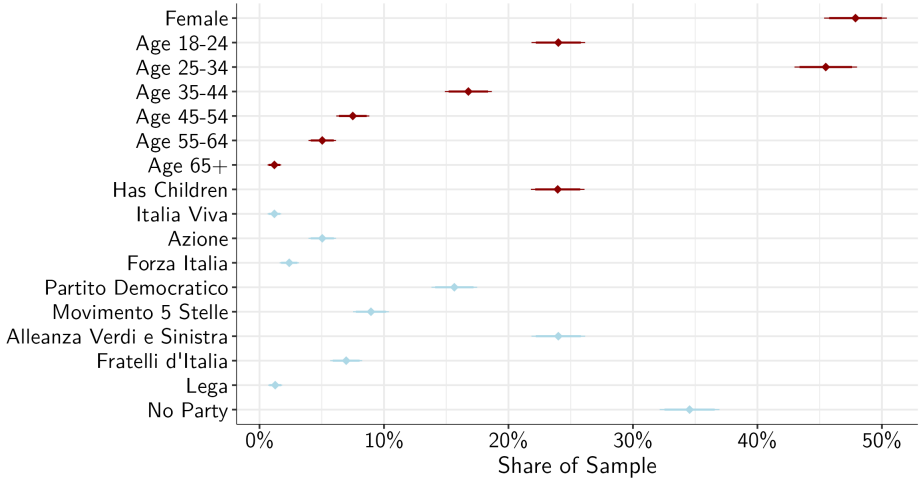
Back

Sample Characteristics

- Mostly men (68%) and between 25 and 44 years old (65%) Demographics Geographical Distr.
- Not representative of the political spectrum except for no voting: left is overrepresented (35%) and right is underrepresented (11%) Demographics and Voting Pref.
- Mostly getting news from social media (73%), online newspapers (68%), and TV (55%) News Consumption
- Mostly progressive gender norms with more mixed evidence opinions for the family structure Gender Norms

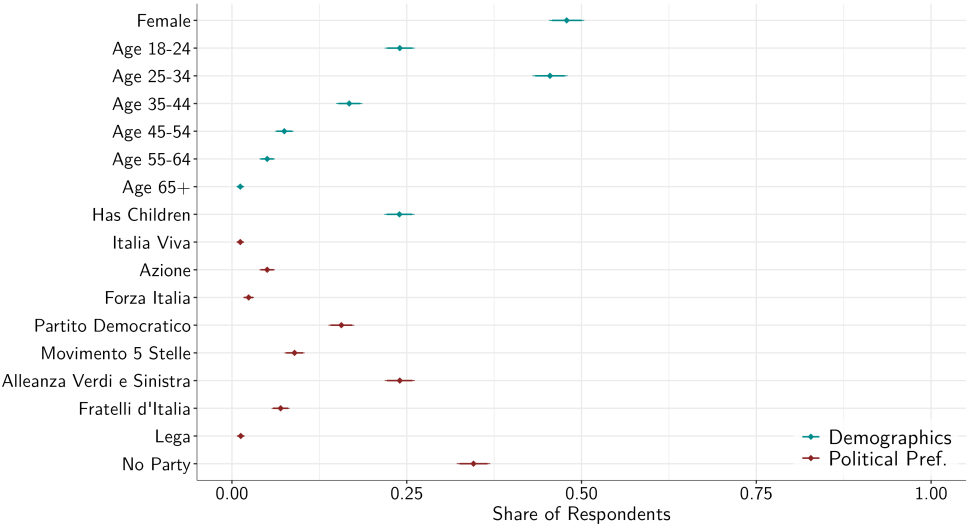
Back

Pre-Survey Questions: Demographics



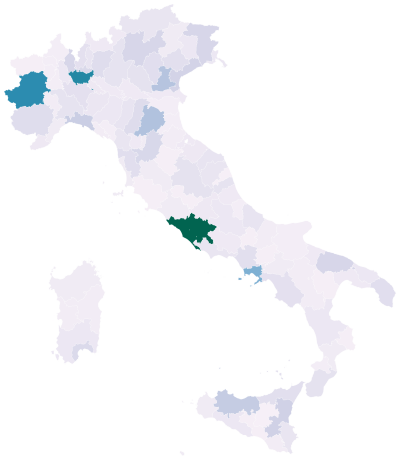
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Pre-Survey Questions: Demographics



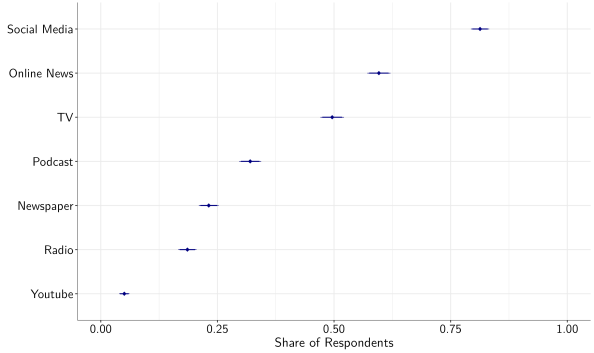
Back

Distribution of Respondents across Provinces



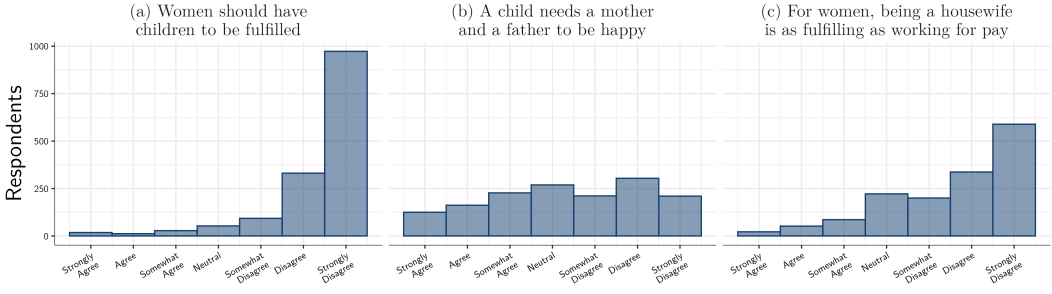
Back

Pre-Survey Questions: News Consumption



Back

Pre-Survey Questions: Gender Norms



Back

Interpreting the Increase in Calls

- Experimental evidence in favor of the social norms channel

Interpreting the Increase in Calls

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More Calls $\neq$ Welfare Improvement

- Increase in calls is consistent with different scenarios:
  - Earlier help-seeking, before violence escalates (*prevention*)
  - Recognition of an abusive relationship (*reporting*)
  - An increase in violence itself (*escalation*)

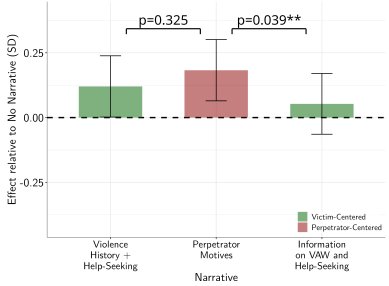
Interpreting the Increase in Calls

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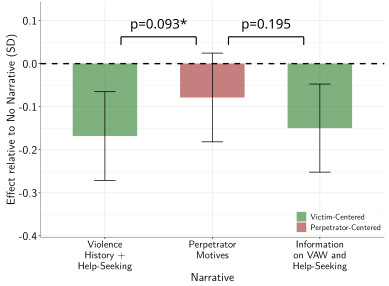
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(a) Empathy towards the Victim

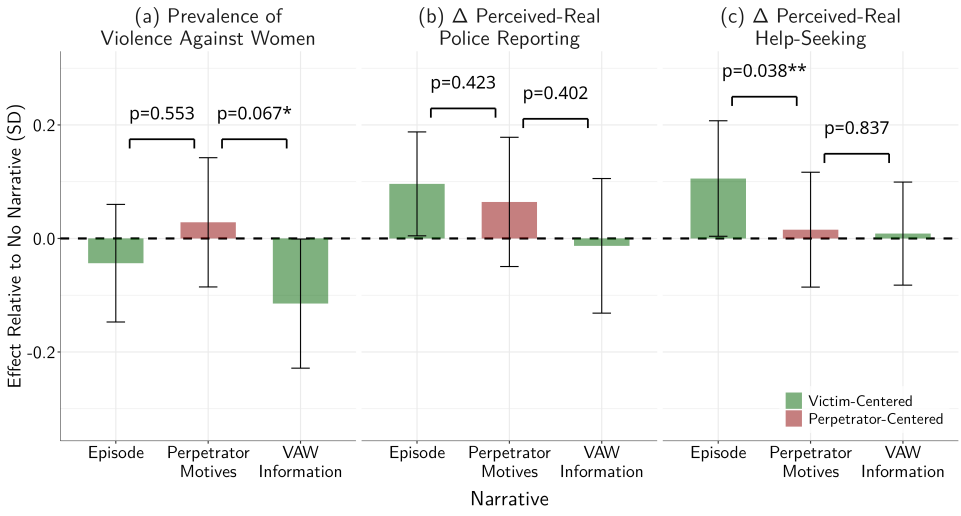


(b) Empathy towards the Perpetrator



Back

Effect on Perceived VAW/Help-Seeking Prevalence: Social Norms Channel

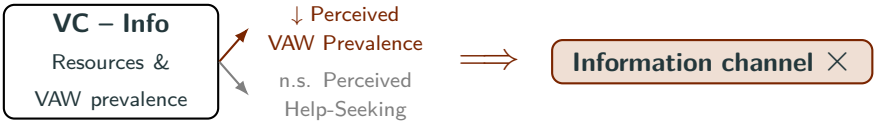


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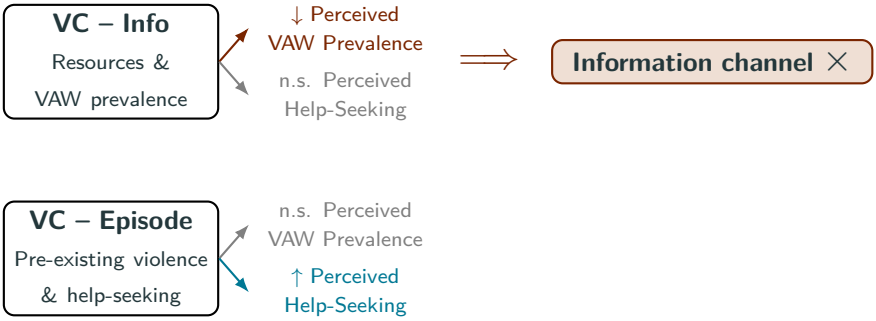
Experimental Evidence



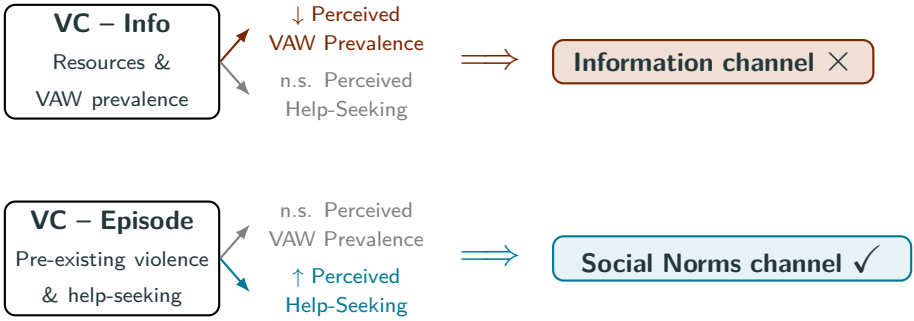
Experimental Evidence



Experimental Evidence

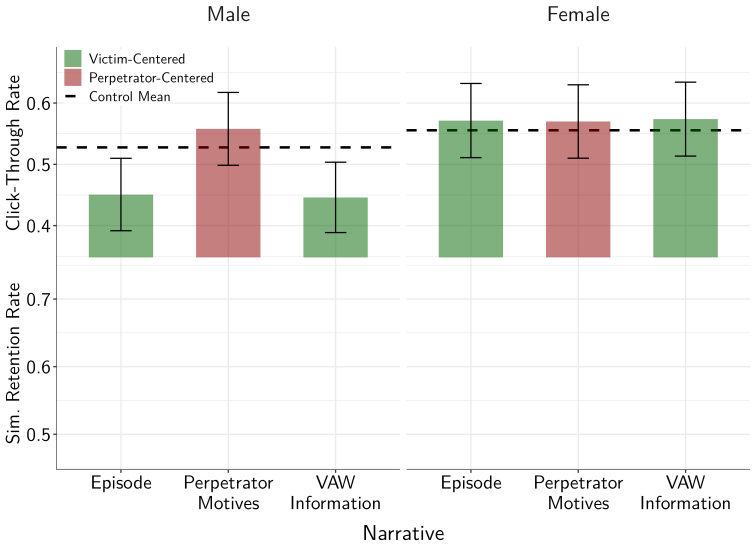


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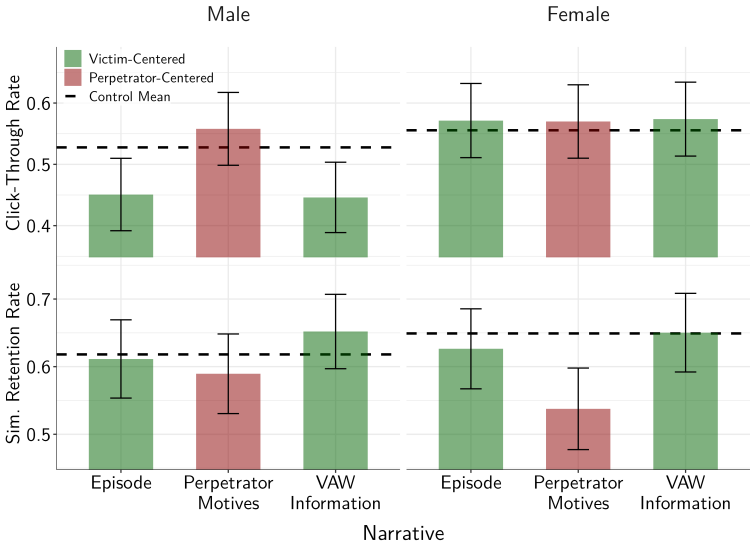


Results Beliefs | Interpretation

Gendered Effect of Narratives on Engagement



Gendered Effect of Narratives on Engagement



Conclusions: Identity of Journalists Matters

- Journalists' identity meaningfully shapes news content
  - Female reporters focus more on the victim and contextualize violence
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  - Increase in help-seeking after greater exposure to female reporters
  - VC narratives lead to a higher perceived prevalence of help-seeking
- Gendered effect on engagement: non-obvious implications for profit-maximizing outlets
  - Trade-off between male engagement and retention of female readers
  - Advantage of personalized content even for traditional outlets?

Conclusions: Identity of Journalists Matters

- Journalists' identity meaningfully shapes news content
  - Female reporters focus more on the victim and contextualize violence
  - Male reporters are more likely to mention jealousy and fits of rage
- Identity-driven narratives affect readers' behavior
  - Increase in help-seeking after greater exposure to female reporters
  - VC narratives lead to a higher perceived prevalence of help-seeking
- Gendered effect on engagement: non-obvious implications for profit-maximizing outlets
  - Trade-off between male engagement and retention of female readers
  - Advantage of personalized content even for traditional outlets?

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